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New York

President: Mrs. Thomas-Greenfield/Ms. Saha/Mr. Wood/Mr. Kelley (United States of America)

Members:

Albania	Mr. Spasse
Brazil	Mr. Cruvinel Barenho
China	Mr. Zhao Shuai
Ecuador	Mr. Fiallo Karolys
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Gabon	Ms. Oye
Ghana	Ms. Arhin
Japan	Mr. Nakagawa
Malta	Ms. Micallef
Mozambique	Mr. Buanahagi
Russian Federation	Mr. Adrianov
Switzerland	Mr. Carpenter
United Arab Emirates	Mr. Azzam
United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland . .	Ms. Kalis

Agenda

Maintenance of international peace and security

Famine and conflict-induced global food insecurity

Letter dated 26 July 2023 from the Permanent Representative of the United States of America to the United Nations addressed to the President of the Security Council (S/2023/560)

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The meeting was resumed at 3 p.m.

The President: I would like to remind all speakers to limit their statements to no more than three minutes in order to enable the Council to carry out its work expeditiously. Flashing lights on the collars of the microphones will prompt speakers to bring their remarks to a close after three minutes.

I now give the floor to the representative of Jordan.

Mr. Hmoud (Jordan): At the outset, allow me to congratulate the United States on assuming the presidency of the Council for the month of August. I would also like to thank you, Madam President, for inviting the briefers who spoke on the role of businesses in fundraising. Involving the private sector begins with including industry leaders in the conversation, and Jordan commends you, Madam President, for leading that effort at the highest political level.

The hunger of people displaced by conflict is the gravest form of food insecurity. The cycle of war and famine triggers a security challenge that is less visible but no less urgent, with overburdened resources preventing countries hosting refugees from providing food to those who need it. No country can tackle that challenge alone, especially developing countries in climate hotspots. In Jordan, where conflict-driven food insecurity affects three of four refugees and nearly 5 per cent of the total population, the need for international solidarity is acute. With one of the lowest levels of water available per person in the world, Jordan has watched increasingly frequent climate-related shocks strain an agricultural industry that is now expected to feed more. Desertification has deepened the vulnerability of Jordan's staple food needs, 80 per cent of which are met through imports.

The mounting needs of refugees are outpacing the pledges of aid. Chronically underfunded United Nations agencies are forced to feed the starving at the expense of the hungry. In Jordan, the World Food Programme (WFP) is meeting the basic food needs of nearly half a million refugees. But just three days ago, the WFP ended cash handouts for more than 50,000 refugees in Jordan, escalating its withdrawal from the two largest refugee camps in the Middle East after it had reduced food subsidies by a third for all of the 120,000 refugees in the Za'atari and Al-Azraq refugee camps last year. In that regard, it should be stressed that it is incumbent on donor States to allocate additional and sufficient resources to meet any new commitments to countries

affected by other conflicts, and not to undercut funding for existing programmes, including funding allocated to the WFP.

The countries that bear the brunt of the hunger-inducing consequences of conflict have agreed to shoulder a tremendous weight, based on a promise that the burdens they have assumed on behalf of the international community will be shared. However, those promises are not being fulfilled, and we worry that prioritizing humanitarian assistance based on the political importance of the conflict to the donor community will expose millions of refugees all over the world to a heightened risk of hunger. Countries that host refugees are performing a global public good, demonstrating solidarity with the priorities of the international community. When Jordan supplies work permits and training to hundreds of thousands of refugees, and when it provides quality health and education services, it sends a message that countries will go beyond their responsibilities as they wait for members of the international community to accept their own responsibility. We expect the Council to assume its responsibility in facilitating sustainable solutions to refugee crises, and the wider United Nations to work towards enabling the safe, dignified and voluntary return of refugees to their homes.

Jordan will be engaged in the Summit of the Future and its preparatory ministerial meeting this autumn to highlight the generational challenge of addressing food insecurity in refugee and host communities. We are eager to hear the Secretary-General's report next year on the progress in following up on this year's Food Systems Summit, and we are ready to help carry the momentum through to the next global stocktaking in 2025. Our collective and swift coordination, as an international community, is key to preventing the world crises that may lie ahead. In the words of His Majesty King Abdullah II in reference to achieving global food security, we must keep working together if we wish to succeed.

Finally, I would like to remind all States of their obligations under international law concerning the protection of civilian populations during armed conflict and in situations of occupation. The suffering and deprivation of the Palestinian people as a result of the Israeli occupation over the decades are a clear example of the need for the Security Council to act to stop such violations against protected populations, something it has consistently failed to do.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Australia.

Mr. Larsen (Australia): I have the honour today to speak on behalf of Canada, New Zealand and my own country, Australia (CANZ).

I thank the United States for its leadership on the issue. I also thank the United Nations Famine Prevention and Response Coordinator, Ms. Reena Ghelani, for her tireless work to strengthen food security and resilience in a time of unprecedented need. This year more than 345 million people are facing acute food insecurity, more than twice the number in 2020. Of those, more than 43 million are now on the brink of famine and nearly 1 million are expected to face catastrophic conditions. We know that food insecurity exacerbates existing inequalities, with women and girls especially affected. The growing scale of food insecurity and human suffering is cause for deep concern.

With climate change, economic shocks and inequalities driving food insecurity, conflict and violence remain the primary causes of hunger, malnutrition and famine. The world is currently facing the highest number of violent conflicts since 1945.

We condemn Russia's decision to walk away from the Black Sea Grain Initiative with full knowledge of the impact that would have on global food prices and the world's most vulnerable. Russia's deliberate targeting and destruction of Ukrainian agricultural and other civilian infrastructure, in flagrant violation of international humanitarian law, has caused terrible loss and damage to Ukraine and exacerbated global food insecurity.

We call on Russia to return to the negotiating table and end its war in Ukraine. We commend the unwavering efforts of Secretary-General Guterres and Türkiye to sustain the vital Black Sea Grain Initiative lifeline. The Initiative remains critical for the stabilization of global food prices and for ensuring that those most vulnerable in Africa, the Indo-Pacific and the Middle East have access to predictable supplies of affordable food.

CANZ will continue to support multilateral approaches to humanitarian challenges. We commend the courage of impartial humanitarian organizations to stay and deliver in increasingly complex environments. We reiterate our strong calls for all parties to adhere to international humanitarian law, including the requirement to ensure timely, safe and unimpeded humanitarian access to all civilians in need.

We recognize that multifaceted crises are stretching humanitarian organizations and the humanitarian system to their limits. We urge all parties to armed conflict to protect civilians, civilian infrastructure and objects essential to the survival of the civilian population, including agri-food systems. We recall the Security Council's repeated unanimous condemnation of starvation as a method of warfare and the need for accountability under international law. We heard the Secretary-General's call to action at the Food Systems Summit and affirm the need to accelerate action on food security and the drivers of conflict in order to get the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development back on track.

Finally, we call for solutions that place humanity above politics.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Oman.

Mr. Al Rubkhi (Oman) (*spoke in Arabic*): I deliver this statement on behalf of the Member States of the Cooperation Council for the Arab States of the Gulf (GCC), namely, the Kingdom of Bahrain, the United Arab Emirates, the State of Kuwait, the State of Qatar, the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia and my country, the Sultanate of Oman, in the context of this debate on famine and conflict-induced global food insecurity.

I would like to begin by thanking the friendly United States of America, President of the Security Council for this month, for inscribing this important issue on the Council's agenda, stressing at the same time that the GCC States are following with great interest the developments of the situations on the regional and international arenas as well as the resultant multiple crises and conflicts. The GCC States believe that the continuation of those crises and conflicts would undermine the ability of the international community to face their repercussions for food security and the stability of States, not to mention their humanitarian impacts on States and peoples alike.

The GCC States would also like to refer in that regard to resolution 2417 (2018), which highlighted the link between armed conflict and violence, on the one hand, and food insecurity and the risk of famine, on the other. It totally rejected practices that violate international humanitarian law, including the illegal prevention of aid and humanitarian material delivery while denying civilians access to life-saving materials. The resolution was submitted by the State of Kuwait,

in partnership with the Kingdom of the Netherlands, Sweden and Côte d'Ivoire, was adopted by consensus and has received wide international support.

The GCC States call for the implementation of the recommendations contained in resolution 2417 (2018) in order to alleviate the effects of the conflict-induced international food crisis and its negative effect on food security. The GCC States call on all parties to armed conflicts to comply with their commitments pursuant to international humanitarian law with regard to the respect and protection of civilians; to commit to not target civilian objects and installations, including those necessary for the production and distribution of food, medicine and vaccines; to refrain from targeting, destroying or damaging any object necessary for the survival of civilians; and to respect and protect humanitarian personnel and shipments.

The GCC States are concerned about the rising level of global humanitarian needs and the threat of famine to many civilians and communities worldwide. Taking General Assembly resolutions 46/182 and 58/114 into account, we emphasize the need to and importance of totally committing to the principles and provisions of the Charter of the United Nations and international law, foremost among which is respecting the sovereignty, independence and territorial integrity of States, non-interference in their internal affairs and respect for good neighbourliness. In accordance with Article 2 of the Charter of the United Nations, Member States must settle international disputes through peaceful means and refrain from the use or threat of use of force in international relations. Any move contrary to those principles must take place legally and officially through a clear mandate of the Security Council, in coordination with the States concerned.

The Council is aware of the efforts made by the GCC States to provide humanitarian assistance in order to address urgent needs, including ensuring food security. In addition to the conflicts we are facing, we note that climate change exacerbates the food insecurity crisis. We therefore believe it is critical to coordinate our international efforts, boost climate action and enhance the resilience of Member States, especially developing countries.

The GCC States call on the international community to redouble its efforts to resolve crises and conflicts on an equal footing. Armed conflicts, violations of international law, international humanitarian law and international human rights law, food insecurity and

starvation policies targeting civilians are among the factors that lead to forced displacement. In countries affected by armed conflict or foreign occupation, those could have a detrimental effect on agricultural production, food security and basic living needs.

The GCC States therefore call on all parties to armed disputes and conflicts to respect international humanitarian law and to provide safe and unimpeded access for humanitarian workers to assist civilians.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Viet Nam.

Mr. Dang (Viet Nam): At the outset, I thank the United States for convening this open debate and welcome the Security Council's continued attention to this important topic.

As highlighted in various recent reports and at the forty-third session of the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations Conference, held last month in Rome, our world faces increasing changes to food security. Even though most sectors have recovered — more or less — from the pandemic, access to food remains an acute problem in many parts of the globe. The causes of food insecurity are complex and manifold, ranging from natural to socioeconomic factors. But it is not accidental that hunger and famine nowadays loom mainly in conflict-affected countries. The correlation between conflicts and conflict-induced hunger has been widely recognized. More joint efforts are needed to break this vicious cycle.

In that connection, I would like to highlight several points.

First, the most effective way to prevent hunger and famine in conflict-affected areas is to address the violence and build peace. The Security Council needs to play a more effective role in addressing the root causes of conflicts, thereby reducing the risk of conflict-induced food insecurity.

Secondly, the Charter of the United Nations and international law, especially humanitarian law, must be strictly upheld in all conflicts. All parties must refrain from any act that threatens the subsistence of civilians in conflict-affected areas, including attacks on and the destruction of objects indispensable to the survival of the civilian population, as stipulated in resolution 2417 (2018) and resolution 2573 (2021), submitted by Viet Nam in April 2021. Civilians, especially women and

children, must not be deprived of access to humanitarian assistance, including food aid.

Thirdly, it is imperative that the United Nations takes a whole-of-system approach to promoting sustainable peace and development and addressing food insecurity. The Security Council needs to work in close coordination with relevant United Nations agencies, such as the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations and the World Food Programme, as well as international donors to combat hunger in conflict-affected areas. Cooperation with regional organizations is also critical, especially when it comes to fostering resilient and accessible food systems and securing global food supply chains.

Having gone through decades of war and transformation from a hunger-stricken country to one of the world's largest exporters of rice and agricultural products, Viet Nam understands first-hand the vital role of food security in sustaining peace and vice versa. Today, food security is both a goal and a means in Viet Nam's socioeconomic development strategy, in which we prioritize the development of low-emission and climate-resilient agriculture and aspire to become a food-innovation hub in the region. Viet Nam continues to actively contribute to global food security through stable exports of rice and various other agricultural products and stands ready to work closely with the international community to address famine and conflict-induced food insecurity.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Thailand.

Mr. Chindawongse (Thailand): I wish to congratulate the United States on assuming the presidency of the Security Council for the month of August and to express appreciation to Secretary of State Blinken for convening and presiding over this important open debate on famine and conflict-induced food insecurity this morning. Our thanks also go to the United Kingdom for the fruitful presidency of the Council last month. And we appreciate the insights provided by the briefers for today's discussions.

What do the *Global Report on Food Crises 2023*, the most recent report of the Secretary-General on the protection of civilians in armed conflict (S/2023/345) and the most current data of the World Food Programme (WFP) have in common? They all point to armed conflict and war being the most significant driver at present of hunger and food insecurity.

The *Global Report on Food Crises 2023*, released in May, showed that more than a quarter of a billion people are facing acute hunger, with economic shocks, extreme weather and conflicts contributing to the increase in that number.

The report of the Secretary-General issued in May 2023 amplifies the connection between armed conflict and violence and conflict-induced food insecurity. And the *Hunger Hotspots. FAO-WFP early warnings on acute food insecurity: June 2023 to November 2023 outlook* of the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations and WFP warns that acute food insecurity is likely to deteriorate further in 18 hunger hotspots from June to November this year, most of which are in conflict situations. And the WFP has indicated that 70 per cent of the world's hungry people live in areas affected by war.

The conclusions are clear: the bad global situation regarding food insecurity is made even worse by war and armed conflict. And there are immense humanitarian consequences. That is why resolution 2417 (2018), which condemns the starving of civilians as a method of warfare, as well as the unlawful denial of humanitarian access, is so significant. The urgency is pressing. The responsibility is ours. So, we need to strengthen collective efforts to address food insecurity exacerbated by armed conflict.

To that end, our focus should be on the following three areas.

First, we must protect civilians in all situations, especially in situations of armed conflict, from hunger and starvation. Thailand stands against the use of food as a weapon of war and calls on parties directly involved in conflicts to commit to taking action with the aim of ensuring that food and the starvation of civilians will never be employed as a tactic of warfare. We call on every Member State and all parties to conflict to respect and fulfil their obligations — humanitarian and legal — to protect civilians in conflict situations and to ensure their food supply. Infrastructure indispensable to the survival of civilians, including objects related to agricultural and food production and distribution, must also be safeguarded.

Secondly, we must ensure a more resilient and better functioning food system to prevent widespread food insecurity and starvation. The impacts of conflict on the food system are more pronounced now than ever and extend far beyond the areas of conflicts owing to the

global nature of the food supply chain. Food insecurity induced by conflicts has disproportionate impacts on low-income and developing countries as they are most exposed to the disruptions on trade in food, agricultural products and fertilizers. Those same countries are also most vulnerable to the fluctuations of food and energy prices, resulting from conflicts and instability.

It is therefore vital to strengthen our global food system and ensure the sustainability of the entire food supply chain. We need to ensure both food affordability and food availability in order to prevent the problem of hunger from escalating to becoming the problem of famine. In that connection, rules and regulations under multilateral trade frameworks need to be conducive to promoting international trade in agricultural and food products. The supply chain should remain open for the unimpeded flow of essential goods such as food, fertilizers and energy. And in certain cases, food assistance and concessional financing should be provided for those in need.

Thirdly and lastly, we must promote more effective climate action for greater food security. Climate change and extreme weather events are threat multipliers. As the Secretary-General has put it, the era of global boiling has underscored the catastrophic consequences of biodiversity loss, extreme weather and unpredictable weather patterns on food production and transportation. Climate-related supply shocks such as crop failures and damage from flooding can drive up food prices even further. Science and technology should therefore be leveraged to ensure sufficient food supplies, as well as improve food storage. Sustainable production of food and agricultural products needs to be promoted to mitigate the risks of vulnerable agricultural areas, food supplies and transportation infrastructure and routes. In the long run, an investment in effective climate action is an investment in the security of the production of food and agricultural products and therefore an investment in combating hunger and starvation.

In conclusion, enhancing food security and the need to prevent starvation and hunger as a result of armed conflict are not only humanitarian imperatives but also signs of the inextricable linkage between sustainable development and international peace, security and stability. Starvation and hunger in conflict situations remind us that without peace, security and stability, sustainable development will be out of our reach and so will the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and the Sustainable Development Goals. So, let us try to, at

the very least, minimize, if not eliminate, the starvation of civilians as a consequence of armed conflict, because that remains central to our continuing and committed efforts to ensure the protection of civilians in armed conflict and to promote food security for all for the long haul.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Slovenia.

Mr. Malovrh (Slovenia): Slovenia aligns itself with the statement of the European Union. We wish to make additional remarks in our national capacity. We also express our gratitude to the United States for the organization of this open debate and extend our appreciation to the briefers.

I would like to draw the Council's attention to three key points.

Slovenia is deeply concerned by the alarming trends in global food insecurity. It is disheartening to witness the world regressing in its efforts to eradicate hunger, food insecurity and malnutrition in all its manifestations. In 2022, over a quarter of a billion people experienced acute hunger in 58 countries and territories, with many of them in armed conflict situations.

As highlighted in resolution 2417 (2018), there is a vicious cycle between armed conflict and food insecurity. Those two issues are intertwined and perpetuate one another.

We acknowledge that conflict and insecurity are the primary drivers of acute food insecurity for 117 million people in 19 countries and territories.

The most recent report of the Secretary-General on the protection of civilians (S/2023/345) reveals several concerning trends regarding the impact of conflict on food and water availability. Behind each trend lies numerous distressing stories: children forced to abandon their education owing to food scarcity, women and girls facing heightened risks of sexual violence while collecting water after dark and fertile agricultural land contaminated with explosive ordnance. Those trends paint a daunting picture. Climate change, manifested through droughts, heavy rainfall, floods and other phenomena, further aggravates hunger in various conflicts. Its repercussions for peace and security are evident and have tangible consequences for millions of people.

The statistics we refer to represent real individuals on the ground. That brings me to my second point,

which is the imperative to uphold international humanitarian law and provide gender-sensitive humanitarian assistance that caters to people's diverse needs. Respect for international humanitarian law has multiple layers. It entails facilitating rapid, safe and unimpeded humanitarian access, as well as preventing any hindrance to that access. It involves preventing the weaponization of access to clean water and food and ensuring the protection of civilian objects, including those necessary for food production and distribution. It also entails respecting and safeguarding civilian personnel. All the parties to a conflict have the obligation to respect and ensure compliance with international humanitarian law in all circumstances.

Lastly, we must enhance coordination to strengthen global food systems. With the increasingly complex root causes of food insecurity and conflicts linked to natural resources, more must be done to address the challenges on the ground and bolster global efforts in the areas of food security, nutrition and resilience. In that regard, we welcome the establishment of the United Nations Famine Prevention and Response Coordinator. We also hope to see further insights into potential strategies for strengthening the work of the High-Level Task Force on Preventing Famine, which brings together United Nations entities, international financial institutions and non-governmental organizations.

Slovenia remains committed to doing its part. Last year we increased our financial support for food security sixfold. As an incoming member of the Security Council, we are looking forward eagerly to collaborating with other members on tangible, action-oriented objectives. Numerous steps can be explored, including improving coordination between humanitarian and development actors, translating early-warning signs into early action using existing tools such as the Framework for Action for Food Security and Nutrition in Protracted Crises and expanding the donor base.

In conclusion, let us not forget that behind our discussions are the lives of real people who are facing the consequences of global food insecurity. Our constructive deliberations in this Chamber can make a meaningful impact on their lives, but only if we are able to foster international cooperation and strengthen their resilience.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Denmark.

Mr. Hermann (Denmark): I have the honour to deliver this statement on behalf of the Nordic countries — Finland, Iceland, Norway, Sweden and my own country, Denmark.

At the outset, I would like to thank the United States for convening this important open debate, as well as the briefers for their statements this morning and most importantly, of course, for the work that they and their colleagues are doing every day to help people in need.

This year has seen conflicts produce devastating effects in many regions, further compounded by the destructive consequences of climate change. The combined effects have upended the lives of millions. Hunger is on the rise and people are suffering. We must do what we can to stop hunger and not accelerate starvation and food insecurity. In that context, the Nordic countries deeply deplore Russia's decision to withdraw from the Black Sea Grain Initiative and condemn its subsequent attacks on Ukrainian ports and grain facilities — facilities that are key to food security in many parts of the world. The Initiative has been critical in helping us to avoid a further deterioration of the global food crisis. It has also helped to stabilize global food prices, which have already shown signs of increasing following Russia's withdrawal.

Resolution 2417 (2018), which was unanimously adopted by the Security Council five years ago, strongly condemns the use of starvation as a method of warfare. It urges the parties to armed conflicts to protect civilian infrastructure and ensure the proper functioning of food systems and markets. In that vein, the Nordic countries have proudly joined the cross-regional group of countries that have co-signed the joint communiqué presented by the United States condemning the use of food as a weapon of war, and we encourage others to join. We must not weaponize food. In line with resolution 2417 (2018), we urge all parties to armed conflict, wherever they are, to fully comply with their obligations under international humanitarian law, ensure safe, rapid, unrestricted humanitarian access and not deprive civilians of things indispensable to their survival.

Conflict often leads to hunger, and hunger often leads to conflict. However, by developing long-term, sustainable and effective global food systems, we can contribute to ending hunger and preventing conflict. But we need to adopt policies and financial instruments to support robust, sustainable and scalable agriculture and food production. And in order to address the issue of

hunger and conflict effectively, we need to work closely and efficiently across the humanitarian-development-peace nexus and to include climate action in the equation. Likewise, collaboration across the public and private sector, as well as with the populations affected, is crucial to delivering the results that people need. To do that, we must ensure full, equal and meaningful participation, as well as protection and access to assistance, in particular for women and girls, who are disproportionately affected by hunger worldwide.

The Nordic countries consider anticipatory action an important tool for taking action ahead of climate shocks to mitigate, reduce and sometimes even avert humanitarian needs and to safeguard long-term development investments. Anticipatory action is a cost-effective tool, saving more lives and livelihoods from climate-induced hunger through the pre-positioning of supplies, including food items and items for food production. In the end, however, nothing can be achieved without adequate, flexible and predictable financial support to both humanitarian and development assistance efforts — and the Nordic countries are and will continue to be reliable contributors of that type of funding.

Let me conclude by reiterating that the Nordic countries will always stand firm on the side of international humanitarian law, and in that context, we call for the universal ratification of the Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court and the two 1977 Protocols Additional to the Geneva Conventions. That would further strengthen international cooperation in the fight to end the use of starvation as a method of warfare.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Guatemala.

Ms. Rodríguez Mancia (Guatemala) (*spoke in Spanish*): Guatemala is grateful for the convening of this open debate and thanks the briefers for their inspiring contributions.

The alarming data on food crisis levels in the *Global Report on Food Crises 2023* reflects the highest such figures seen in the past seven years, owing to interconnected factors such as conflict, insecurity, economic crises, climate change and inequality, which are stretching the capacities of food systems to provide nutritious, safe and affordable food for all.

It is urgent to address climate change while recalling that it is a dangerous risk multiplier that exacerbates

humanitarian crises, conflicts and instability, especially in fragile situations in which Governments have limited means to help their populations adapt. In the face of that, we need to protect the most vulnerable and take immediate action to save lives by improving the security environment and humanitarian response with a focus on building more resilient and peaceful communities. In that regard, we look forward to the discussions on the New Agenda for Peace and the proposed Pact for the Future, with a view to strengthening cross-cutting action across the pillars of the United Nations, through which we can advance our fulfilment of the Sustainable Development Goals and prevent and address humanitarian crises and conflicts in a coherent and complementary manner in order to ensure world peace and security. We also believe that the multilateral system has much to do in terms of mobilizing resources and their means of implementation, including through the use of science, technology and innovation for the most vulnerable countries as well as partnerships with the private sector and civil society. As the Secretary-General said in his opening remarks at the Food Systems Summit,

“There is more than enough money to fund efficient and sustainable food systems to feed the world, while supporting decent work for those who grow the food we eat”.

We deeply regret that the Russian Federation has terminated the Black Sea Grain Initiative and withdrawn its security guarantees for ships sailing in the north-western part of the Black Sea, given the direct negative impact it will have on humanitarian operations contributing to alleviating global hunger through the more than 32 million metric tons of food products shipped from Ukrainian ports. The Russian Federation’s illegal, unjustified and unprovoked aggression against Ukraine and the actions it has taken since the outbreak of hostilities have jeopardized global food security and caused a macroeconomic destabilization of food prices, with devastating consequences that include people’s forced displacement and lost access to livelihoods and income, which in turn require the deployment of a humanitarian response. Finally, Guatemala calls for more determined joint action to prevent the structural challenges that cause conflicts and imperil world peace and security, and to make progress on finding robust solutions to those challenges.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Guyana.

Mr. Hinds (Guyana): Guyana welcomes the convening of this high-level open debate on famine and conflict-induced global food insecurity. We commend the United States for bringing this important issue to the fore and express our appreciation for the briefings we heard this morning. We also welcome the appointment of Ms. Reena Ghelani as the United Nations Famine Prevention and Response Coordinator.

The right to food is a human right and a humanitarian imperative. No one anywhere in today's world should live with hunger or suffer malnutrition. Through Sustainable Development Goal 2, our global community has committed to ending hunger, achieving food security and improved nutrition and promoting sustainable agriculture. Guyana is resolutely committed to that goal, as is the Caribbean Community (CARICOM), whose efforts in that regard Guyana has the honour to lead.

Food must never be used as a weapon of war. The international community must unite around that principle and ensure that it is fulfilled in practice through solutions that meet the needs of all who are affected. This year we marked the fifth anniversary of the unanimous adoption of resolution 2417 (2018), which pointed to the links between armed conflict and conflict-induced food insecurity and the threat of famine. We have an important opportunity to renew our high-level political commitment to its full and effective implementation and to work collectively to enhance the protection of civilians against food insecurity in situations of armed conflict.

The disconcerting *Global Report on Food Crises 2023* reveals that more than a quarter of a billion people in 58 countries are acutely food insecure and in need of urgent food assistance. That is one in every 32 persons on the planet. Conflict remains one of the main drivers of acute food insecurity, with 117.1 million people affected — not to mention others such as the impact of economic shocks and weather extremes, which have left an additional 83.9 million and 56.8 million people, respectively, in acute food insecurity. Guyana would like to express its solidarity with the countries affected, including our CARICOM sister State of Haiti. Taken together, those numbers are the highest in the seven-year history of the *Global Report on Food Crises*, and yet an additional 400 million to 500 million human beings faced hunger in 2022, according to the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations.

Those multiple and interlinked challenges, and the associated impacts of disrupted supply chains and higher prices for food, fuel and fertilizer, are not beyond our collective ability to address. They demand our urgent attention and represent a real call to united action in the true spirit of multilateralism. In that connection, Guyana underscores the need to address global food insecurity holistically, through the pursuit of targeted and path-breaking initiatives such as the United Nations Food Systems Summit+2 and its recent Stocktaking Moment, as well as regional and national efforts. Guyana urges for renewed efforts by all the parties concerned in the Black Sea Grain Initiative to bring it back on track.

Urgent action is required to transform agrifood systems to make them more resilient and lower the cost of nutritious food and healthy diets for all. As the lead member of CARICOM for agriculture, agricultural diversification and food security, Guyana is working with its sister States on ambitious initiatives to reinvigorate the growth and development of the agrifood sector, boosting regional production with a view to reducing the regional food import bill by 25 per cent by 2025 and enhancing food and nutrition security in the region. Our national efforts are in concert with those objectives and aim to fortify and diversify our agrifood sector, including through increased budgetary allocations, investment in research and supportive infrastructure and the adoption of climate-smart technologies.

In closing, Guyana remains a committed partner in efforts to promote food security and address the causes of food insecurity, including those induced by conflict. In that spirit, Guyana is pleased to subscribe to the joint communiqué condemning the use of food as a weapon of war.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Türkiye.

Mr. Kayalar (Türkiye): I thank you for convening this debate, Madam President, and the briefers for their presentations.

Türkiye attaches the utmost importance to the preservation and smooth functioning of global supply chains in order to safeguard food security in all circumstances, including during pandemics and conflict situations. We stand firmly against attempts to undermine food security for political or military motives. All parties to armed conflicts should respect core humanitarian principles. Through its competent

agencies such as the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, the United Nations is well positioned to play a leading role in coordinating international efforts involving States, civil society and the private sector.

Since ensuring food security remains a critical challenge worldwide, it is also at the heart of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. Although the international community has made considerable progress in that regard, much work remains to be done to achieve the relevant Sustainable Development Goals, as we are still a long way from attaining our goals of zero hunger, food security and nutrition. Security and food crises are mutually reinforcing and create a vicious cycle. On top of that, the effects of climate change put additional stress on agricultural systems, making it even more difficult to satisfy the needs of rapidly growing populations.

The ongoing war in Ukraine between the world's two key agricultural producers has further jeopardized our already fragile global food security. The Black Sea Grain Initiative has functioned as an effective mechanism for addressing that fragility and stabilizing food prices for almost a year. Its termination unquestionably poses a challenge that we must tackle together. If our efforts are to yield concrete results, all sides should refrain from escalatory steps. Given our role in the launch and implementation of the Initiative, Türkiye remains committed to sustaining its endeavours to revive the Initiative and to taking part in the international efforts to mitigate the impact of the war in Ukraine on global food security.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Ethiopia.

Mr. Sabo (Ethiopia): We congratulate the United States of America on assuming the presidency of the Security Council for the month of August and appreciate the opportunity to contribute to this important discussion on food security.

Regrettably, despite the enormous efforts we are making to address the challenge of food insecurity, it continues to be a source of serious concern. Like other factors that affect societal well-being, conflict undermines people's ability to access sufficient safe and nutritious food that meets their dietary needs. The recent *Sustainable Development Goals Report 2023: Special Edition* indicates that 2.4 billion people are facing food insecurity, with 830 million of them affected

by hunger. If the current level of implementation of the Sustainable Development Goals stays the same, by the end of 2030 8 per cent of the global population will still be suffering from hunger. We consider that alarming and therefore deserving of globally concerted action at every level.

While global income inequality is a major factor in people's inability to attain food security, low levels of productivity and production and a lack of resilience to the impacts of climate change are also important contributing factors. In our discussions today, we have listened to many statements that put Africa at the centre of the food security predicament. While that situation is extremely disheartening, it is also a clarion call to action for Africans. We believe it is unacceptable that the people of Africa are facing food shortages while their continent is endowed with land, water and human resources that should be able to feed the entire world. Global solidarity and a unity of purpose in assisting us in harnessing our national endowments would make a difference.

The African Union has a continental agenda that targets the complete elimination of hunger and food insecurity on the continent. We are also working to reduce food imports and increase intra-African trade in agriculture by 50 per cent. Based on that continent-wide aspiration and our national development objectives, Ethiopia is on track to achieve that target. Our summer irrigation initiative has enabled us to produce surplus wheat for export after covering the national demand. Our national nutrition programme, known as Yelemat Tirufat — which roughly translates to “bounty of the basket” — is changing production patterns and having a positive impact on attitudes and practices related to food and nutrition. Our own experiment has convinced us that food security is an attainable goal for all of Africa. It is on that basis that we call on the international community, including the United Nations and international financial institutions, to support our agriculture and food production sector. In that regard, I would like to make three points.

First, food insecurity is primarily a manifestation of extreme poverty and underdevelopment. Accelerating development and collective action for the attainment of the Sustainable Development Goals should be a rallying point for our course of action.

Secondly, trade practices that perpetuate African countries' dependency on food imports must be transformed. Increasing production on the continent

and strengthening intracontinental trade is crucial and deserves the necessary support.

Thirdly, as can be seen in the Secretary-General's report *Making food systems work for people and planet*, financing the transformation of food systems is ranked as the first area of support requested by Member States. For Africa, increased productivity requires modern agriculture and added value, as well as enhanced investment to attract and retain young people in the agriculture and food production sector. International financial support to ensure long-term development goals, even in situations of conflict, is therefore imperative.

In conclusion, while enhancing our support for the resolution of conflicts, we should also be mindful of emergency measures and the provision of humanitarian assistance. In the meantime, we need to ensure that we do not lose sight of the lasting remedy that is enhancing productivity, strengthening resilience and alleviating food insecurity. Through development we can break the cycle of poverty, conflict and food insecurity.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Chile.

Mrs. Narváez Ojeda (Chile) (*spoke in Spanish*): Chile thanks the United States for convening this open debate and takes note of the briefings and contributions we have heard. We wish the United States every success during its presidency of the Council this month. I will read an abridged version of our statement today in order to respect the time limit, and we will circulate the full version.

We would like to reaffirm the responsibility and importance of multilateral work in ensuring joint and coordinated responses to the world's severe food and humanitarian crisis. We believe it is vital for each Member State to safeguard its citizens' right to food and strengthen the assets that form the basis of its national food system, with the aim of contributing to food and nutrition security now and in the future. However, conflict, climate change, terrorism, violent extremism, the use of explosive devices, proliferating armed groups and economic instability mean that famine and food insecurity persist, making it impossible to foster a healthy food environment and promote the consumption of a nutrient-rich, balanced and safe diet. We call on the international community to step up innovation, learn from successful and replicable experiences and promote programmes and initiatives

that can strengthen the production of essential food for national and local consumption in areas that are sensitive where international peace and security are concerned. We call for respect for and compliance with resolution 2417 (2018).

We want to emphasize that one of our chief concerns here is the fact that women, children, indigenous peoples and elderly persons are the main victims of food insecurity and conflict. There is no question that gaps in access to food resources for those groups need to be urgently reduced. In that regard, we would like to highlight the role of women in family farming, small-scale agriculture, artisanal fishing and small-scale aquaculture, as they are capable of making improvements in adverse circumstances and where production chains barely exist. It is therefore essential to promote initiatives that enable women to access land, productive resources and marketing channels so that they can strengthen their decision-making power in agricultural production, generate economic income and improve their living conditions.

Another aspect we want to highlight is the urgent task of correcting market distortions and failures in order to facilitate coordination between the various links in food production supply chains. We are disturbed by the fact that some Member States have taken steps such as closing markets or imposing unilateral coercive measures or unjustified barriers to trade in food and related products, among other things, because such measures completely contradict the goal of reducing hunger and violate basic humanitarian commitments. We believe in food trade based on the rules of the World Trade Organization. In that regard, we reaffirm our commitment to maintaining fair, open, inclusive and predictable agricultural markets to ensure a continued flow of agricultural products and elements essential to agricultural production, including fertilizers.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Italy.

Mr. Greco (Italy): Italy aligns itself with the statement to be delivered on behalf of the European Union and would like to add a few remarks in its national capacity.

The importance that the United States traditionally attaches to this dossier, which is also a priority for us, is highly appreciated. We therefore thank the presidency for convening today's meeting to discuss and report on the risk of conflict-induced famine and widespread

food insecurity. That risk is unfortunately a current and gloomy picture in too many countries, and the topic is now more urgent and alarming than ever. We deeply regret the decision taken by the Russian Federation to oppose the renewal of the Black Sea Grain Initiative, a beacon of hope for many countries in Africa and elsewhere. We reiterate our call on Russia to rejoin the initiative, stop using food as a weapon and cease its illegal blockade of Ukrainian sea ports. We will continue to support all efforts towards a resumption of that key initiative.

Italy once again stresses the importance of resolution 2417 (2018) and its unanimous adoption a mere five years ago. We have all the tools to safeguard civilians at risk. We just need to demonstrate the necessary political commitment and take action.

Respect for international humanitarian law is not optional. Humanitarian personnel should be able to travel safely in any circumstances, particularly when food supplies and distribution are at stake. The use of starvation as a method of warfare is explicitly prohibited by international law, which too many people seem to forget. Italy also remains dedicated to addressing global food insecurity, particularly considering its role as the host country of the United Nations food agencies. Last week in Rome the Italian Government organized the United Nations Food Systems Summit+2 Stocktaking Moment to assess the results of the efforts made so far. During three intense days of work we saw proposals for concrete, innovative and inclusive solutions addressing the challenges that we are facing today. The linkages among food security, climate and security were also thoroughly addressed. Following all the discussions and the engagement that we just renewed in Rome, food security will also be at the top of the agenda of the Italian presidency of the Group of Seven next year.

Italy urges the international community to redouble its efforts and take decisive action to address the pressing challenges of food insecurity, protect essential services and create a safer and more dignified future for all civilians affected by conflicts worldwide.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of India.

Mrs. Kamboj (India): Let me begin by expressing my delegation's appreciation to the United States for its presidency of the Security Council and bringing into focus the crucial issue of conflict-induced food insecurity. Given the time constraints, I will be

brief and submit the following suggestions for the Council's consideration.

First and foremost, we must work together to find common solutions through dialogue and diplomacy. Choosing peace, cooperation and multilateralism will be essential to building our collective future. Strengthening the international architecture and governance systems to protect the global order, global laws and global values must therefore be a shared responsibility.

Secondly, addressing the growing food grain shortages requires us to go beyond the current constraints. As far as India is concerned, we are fully committed to playing our part in addressing contemporary global challenges, as reflected in our membership as Champions in the Global Crisis Response Group.

Thirdly, India supports the efforts of the Secretary-General in continuing the Black Sea Grain Initiative and hopes for an early resolution to the current impasse. Recent developments regarding that issue have not helped to secure the larger cause of peace and stability.

I would like to say very briefly that India has always been proactive in assisting its partners in times of distress. Even in the middle of the coronavirus disease pandemic, India provided food aid in the form of thousands of metric tons of wheat, rice, pulses and lentils to a number of countries, including in our neighbourhood and in Africa, in order to strengthen food security. In view of the deteriorating humanitarian situation in Afghanistan, India has commenced a donation of 50,000 metric ton of wheat to the people of Afghanistan. Similarly, we have continued our humanitarian support to Myanmar, including with a grant of 10,000 tons of rice and wheat. We have also assisted Sri Lanka, including with food assistance, during its difficult times. All of that is in keeping with our foreign-policy priority of Neighbourhood First and our firm belief in the abiding ethos of *vasudhaiva kutumbakam*, by which India sees the world as one large interconnected family.

In leveraging its presidency of the Group of 20, India has advocated for greater efforts to accelerate the achievement of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), including SDG 2, calling for zero hunger. In our Prime Minister's words, the Indian presidency is committed to

“[d]epoliticizing the global supply of food, fertilizers and medical products so that geopolitical tensions do not lead to humanitarian crises.”

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Kenya.

Mr. Kimani (Kenya): I would like to warmly congratulate the United States on assuming the presidency of the Security Council for the month of August.

Food is the most fundamental human need and therefore pivotal to any comprehensive discussion of international security, development and human rights. In the Horn of Africa and the Sahel, to take just two prominent examples, more than 29 million people are food insecure today. The crisis is directly linked to civil wars, terrorism, regional conflicts and inadequate development models. It is also reasonable to argue that the military coups across the Sahel may lead to serious shortfalls in trade and investment, potentially restricting people's access to affordable nutrition. We are encouraged to suggest that the effectiveness of preventive diplomacy and mediation emerges as the most important intervening factor in this area. United Nations specialized agencies, and their international and regional counterparts, must also strive to do a better job of linking humanitarian action with development and livelihood support. Strong climate action linked to peacebuilding and security, including robust investment in the Loss and Damage Fund agreed to at the twenty-seventh Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (COP27), will be indispensable to addressing global food insecurity. We urge the membership to embrace those recommendations at the inaugural Africa Climate Summit, to be held in Nairobi, and at the Sustainable Development Goal Summit in September and COP28, in November. We also call for a ceasefire in Ukraine, and a resumption of negotiations on and ultimately the unconditional renewal and reinvigoration of the Black Sea Grain Initiative, which facilitates the exports of both Ukrainian and Russian food and fertilizers.

In the face of dire emergencies, we must do more than express alarm without taking action. I would like to direct the Council's attention to Haiti, a nation grappling with unprecedented food insecurity. The World Food Programme has reported that the number of food-insecure Haitians has tripled since 2016. Nearly half of the country's population struggles to find enough to eat, and 1.8 million are facing emergency

levels of food insecurity. The situation is particularly dire for children, 22 per cent of whom are chronically malnourished, with 66 per cent of those under five years of age suffering from anaemia. The contributing factors are diverse. In the context of today's debate, they include the gangs that are controlling large parts of the country. Kenya is encouraged by the Security Council's willingness to consider authorizing a multinational police force to work with the Haitian authorities to counter gang violence and secure critical infrastructure. We recently announced our readiness to volunteer a police contingent and look forward to working with the Bahamas and other Member States willing to step up to fulfil that responsibility.

However, such a force, while necessary, is not sufficient on its own. We urge the United Nations and relevant actors to concurrently develop a coordinated package that learns from the past and at a minimum includes peacebuilding, constitutional review, institutional reforms, community mediation, support for victims of sexual violence and social and economic development, including the reconstruction of civilian infrastructure. Those interlocking initiatives must be anchored in strong partnerships, including with the Caribbean Community, to respond cohesively to Haiti's urgent needs. It will be an opportunity to show solidarity with the people of Haiti, as well as to renew the faltering efforts of the United Nations in ensuring international peace and security.

The President: I now give the floor to Mr. Camelli.

Mr. Camelli (*spoke in French*): I have the honour to speak on behalf of the European Union and its member States. The candidate countries North Macedonia, Montenegro, Albania, Ukraine, the Republic of Moldova and Bosnia and Herzegovina and the potential candidate country Georgia, as well as Andorra, Monaco and San Marino, align themselves with this statement.

I would first like to congratulate you, Madam President, on the start of your presidency of the Security Council, and to thank you for convening this particularly important debate.

Russia's decision to end the Black Sea Grain Initiative has only exacerbated the global food crisis. With the solidarity lanes between the European Union and Ukraine, the partial reopening of Black Sea ports helped stabilize and even lower food prices. Those prices reached unprecedented levels because of Russia's war of aggression on Ukraine. We therefore reiterate

our call on Russia to stop using food as a weapon, rejoin the Black Sea Grain Initiative and cease illegally blocking Ukrainian seaports.

We are moving in the wrong direction. Despite the unanimous adoption of resolution 2417 (2018) five years ago, conflict-induced food insecurity is on the rise. Regrettably, we are seeing it in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Burkina Faso, Mali, the Sudan, Yemen and Haiti. We all have a collective responsibility to eradicate hunger and save lives. The European Union has been at the forefront of global efforts to combat food insecurity and malnutrition. In 2022, we allocated more than €1 billion in humanitarian food and nutrition assistance. Today I would like to make three points.

First, the starvation of civilians as a tactic of war is a violation of international humanitarian law and can constitute a war crime. Yet in too many conflicts we have continued to see the weaponization of access to clean water and food, which are crucial to civilians' survival. Too often, parties to conflict intentionally hinder humanitarian access. And too often, humanitarian workers dedicated to saving others become targets themselves. This should be universally condemned. We call on all parties to armed conflicts to respect international humanitarian law. That includes facilitating rapid, safe and unimpeded humanitarian access. For their part, the European Union and its member States will continue to advocate for compliance with international humanitarian law, accountability for violations of that law and the systematic implementation of resolution 2417 (2018). The European Union also funds an initiative aimed at enhancing evidence-based reporting on conflict-induced hunger by reinforcing and complementing existing accountability mechanisms.

Secondly, the unprecedented global food crisis we are dealing with requires urgent, coordinated and unified action. The United Nations Food Systems Summit+2 reignited momentum in that regard. It is now more vital than ever that we remain united in our purpose. That means we must strive for greater complementarity between humanitarian, development and peace actions at every level if we are to protect essential resources. We need those efforts to enable us to address the root causes of hunger and conflict. In that regard, the European Union fully supports the role and leadership of the United Nations in the response to the global food crisis, and we call on the international community to maintain its levels of funding in order to address the growing needs. However, as long as the

conflicts continue, funding alone will not be enough to achieve food security.

Thirdly and lastly, we must address the linkages among food security, climate and security. Climate change and extreme weather are both drivers of hunger and sources of conflict. Millions are forcibly displaced every year by flooding and drought, increasing food insecurity. We must change course and shift from reactive approaches — even if they continue to be necessary — to a proactive vision aimed at preventing the humanitarian consequences of climate change and hunger crises. We must work together to strengthen anticipatory action systems and ensure that emergency actions also reach remote communities and those affected by conflict, including women and girls.

Thanks to Team Europe's comprehensive approach, the European Union and its member States remain committed to supporting investments to address the root causes of food insecurity and malnutrition in fragile and conflict-affected settings.

The President: I now give the floor to Mr. Beresford-Hill.

Mr. Beresford-Hill: I would like to express my appreciation and congratulations to you, Madam President, on your country's assumption of the presidency of the Security Council for this month, and to thank the United States and the Council members for organizing today's crucial debate and granting us the privilege of being part of the discussion. I also want to express my appreciation for the successful July presidency of my United Kingdom colleagues.

Earlier today we heard harrowing and heartbreaking testimonies from three briefers, who gave us a very human perspective on the dilemma that is facing our world, and I thank Reena Ghelani, Navyn Salem and David Miliband for their contributions. The statistics are undeniable. Imagine a quarter of a billion human beings experiencing hunger, standing on a huge desert plain. A mile away, in verdant pastures with cool running waters, we see enough food, loaves of bread, fish, meat and vegetation to fill all of those people and millions more. And between those two images of hunger and plenty we see barbed wire, landmines, trenches, destroyed bridges and roads and eyes staring across the divide with hatred. That is what humankind has been reduced to. And that is why we are here today. It is a problem that we are all called on to solve.

The topic holds immense significance for us at the Sovereign Order of Malta because we have diligently dedicated ourselves to providing humanitarian care and medical services to the poor and sick across the globe for 900 years. Operating in 122 countries and holding bilateral and diplomatic relations with 114, we have a special focus on the Middle East and Africa, providing humanitarian aid through health care, water, sanitation and hygiene, disaster preparedness and food security. Regrettably, the Ukrainian conflict, especially through the breakdown of the Black Sea Grain Initiative, has significantly hindered our humanitarian efforts in the Middle East and Africa. As reported by the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations, the Initiative played a significant role in reducing global food prices by more than 23 per cent over the past year, benefiting food security across many regions. However, since the collapse of the Initiative, wheat prices have risen in global markets, leading to challenges in securing affordable food supplies. In particular, our extensive involvement in food distribution operations in Ethiopia, Kenya and South Sudan relies heavily on the supply of grain from Russia and Ukraine. Consequently, escalating expenses from sourcing agents, along with higher costs for distribution, have nearly doubled operational costs, and there are expectations of further increases. Furthermore, those developments have created immediate humanitarian crises in numerous countries in which we function.

The breakdown of the Initiative has far-reaching consequences, not only worsening food security issues in various regions but also placing an additional burden on affected populations seeking medical assistance due to malnutrition. There is a thin line between nutrition and health care, as an increase in illness and loss of life from starvation and malnourishment burdens the aid workers, volunteers and medical providers striving to build and maintain a sustainable future in developing nations. Seeking parallels in history, we think of South Asia, particularly Bangladesh between 1970 and 1974, where we saw how environmental and human-made factors can combine to have significant repercussions for the civilian population. During that period, the interplay between inadequate preparedness and a lack of post-crisis care against a backdrop of both natural disaster and military conflict led to the loss of approximately 2 million lives due to undernutrition and starvation.

The recent collapse of the Black Sea Grain Initiative raises concerns about the potential for a similar

humanitarian disaster, particularly in vulnerable parts of Africa, if the underlying issues are not promptly addressed. In conclusion, I would like to quote the words of Pope Francis, who recently said,

“I appeal to my brothers [and sisters], the authorities of the Russian Federation, so that the Black Sea Initiative may be restored, and grain may be transported safely”.

To that prayer, I think we should all say “Amen”.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Yemen.

Mr. Al-dobhany (Yemen) (*spoke in Arabic*): I thank you, Madam President, and thank the briefers for their valuable briefings.

Over the past few years, the coronavirus disease pandemic has created many challenges that have greatly affected food security throughout the world. Food prices have reached record highs owing to demand and transport costs that have increased, as well as imbalances in the work of ports. Today, the ongoing conflicts at the international level increase the existing challenges and the make global food crisis even worse.

The Government of my country is aware of the urgency of addressing famine and conflict-induced global food insecurity. Yemen is one of the countries listed in the *Global Report on Food Crises 2023*. According to the report, more than 24 million Yemenis are in need of humanitarian assistance while more than 20 million people are facing famine. That bleak picture of the situation in Yemen is due to the war waged by the Houthi militias against the Yemeni people since 2014.

The Government of my country is deeply concerned by the exacerbation of food insecurity in Yemen, and it is struggling owing to a contraction of the national economy by half as a result of the war and the continued threats and terrorist attacks by the Houthis against vital economic facilities and oil ports. Since August 2022, my country has lost nearly \$1.5 billion earmarked for improving public services and paying salaries across the country. Developments in world events also increased the food crisis in Yemen and other third-world countries affected by conflicts and climate challenges.

Yemen is aware of the challenges facing the world and the vital role that all of us can play in promoting food security and addressing famine through the following actions.

We must act together to promote proactive measures that strengthen our ability to predict and avert food supply crises. In that regard, we stress the need to adopt effective measures to address challenges early on through coordination and exchanging information and data among various parties, as well as developing crisis analysis and urgent response mechanisms.

Yemen is one of the countries that produce least amount of carbon dioxide. However, it is most affected by climate change. Since the coup by the Houthi militias nine years ago, Yemen has been left behind in many sectors especially those related to promoting agriculture and rural development in order to address the root causes of food insecurity.

Like other countries in conflict or post-conflict situations, Yemen is in dire need of strengthening the capabilities of State institutions in order to effectively respond to the threats of climate change. We stress in that regard the need for support from Member States and the private sector to improve our agricultural capabilities. We need the necessary funding to establish food security at the State level and to enable the agricultural communities to address challenges and adapt to environmental changes while dealing with water scarcity and soil degradation along with promoting sustainable agriculture.

As a State with a long coastal border, Yemen is aware of the importance of sustainable fisheries to achieving food security. We call on the international community, donors and international organizations to support our fishing and aquaculture sectors in order to improve the lives of coastal communities and enhance food security. In that context, I thank once again the United Nations Development Programme and other donors that have helped us to address the FSO SAFER oil tanker, whose rescue operation we hope will be completed very soon.

Yemen is in need of more humanitarian aid to meet urgent need for food of millions of Yemenis. We hope that the humanitarian response plan will be supported in order to provide food, clean water, basic health care and protection. I take this opportunity to thank the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia for its recent donation of \$1.2 billion to make up for the budgetary shortfall in Yemen.

Due to the conflict in Yemen, we need more humanitarian aid, especially for the most vulnerable. We call on the international community to put pressure

on the Houthi militias to ensure safe, unhindered and sustained access to life-saving humanitarian aid, especially for children under five and for women and girls who are more vulnerable to acute malnutrition. The Houthi militias must refrain from using starvation of civilians as a method of warfare, especially when this heinous tactic is used against civilians, especially those residing in Taiz, a city that has been under blockade for more than eight years.

We must invest in long-term strategies to promote resilience and improve livelihoods for vulnerable communities. Specialized international organizations and agencies can play a vital role in supporting small-scale farmers in the rural part of Yemen, who make up 70 per cent of the population, in order to enhance agricultural practices and create more jobs. That would lead to livelihood diversification, enhancing peaceful coexistence and depending less on humanitarian aid.

My country's Government encourages partnership between private and public sectors to benefit from the expertise and resources of both sectors in order to address food insecurity. Investment, technology and innovation must be enhanced to promote agricultural productivity and food distribution. We must make efforts to protect production activities and marketing necessary to meet the domestic and international demand. Supply chains must continue to operate, which leads to the protection of existing infrastructure in order to provide crops, livestock, food and other logistics systems.

In conclusion, women must have a role in the food production and distribution process. All restrictions imposed on women, especially in areas controlled by the Houthi militias, must be lifted. We call for enabling women farmers and businesswomen through improving access to resources, financing and training. That will lead to the promotion of food security within families and communities.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Morocco.

Mr. Kadiri (Morocco) (*spoke in French*): At the outset, I would like to warmly congratulate you, Madam President, on your presidency of the Security Council this month and to assure you of Morocco's full cooperation. We also thank you, Madam, for organizing this debate, which has been enriched by the participation the Secretary of State of the United States, His Excellency Antony Blinken. We commend you, Madam, on the adoption this morning of the important

presidential statement S/PRST/2023/4 presented by the United States. I would also like to take this opportunity to thank the briefers for taking part in this open debate and for their comprehensive briefings.

The world is currently facing a number of tensions that have exacerbated a multifaceted crisis in terms of food, energy, climate and finance, which has a particular impact on the most vulnerable countries, including the African countries. In this fragile context marked by interconnected crises, which are eroding our capacity for a collective response, the implementation of Sustainable Development Goal 2 on ending hunger, achieving food security and improving nutrition is at great risk. That requires a collective response that is humanitarian in nature, conducive to development and centred on peace, with a special focus placed on prevention, and strengthened by a food security expert with a particular focus on prevention.

Five years ago, the Security Council unanimously adopted resolution 2417 (2018), which highlighted links between armed conflict and violence, on one hand, and food insecurity caused by conflict and famine, on the other. That resolution strongly condemns violations of international humanitarian law and wilful obstruction of the delivery of humanitarian assistance. Moreover, as stipulated in operative paragraph 9 of the resolution, the Council must adopt sanction measures against individuals or entities obstructing the delivery of humanitarian assistance, or access to, or distribution of, humanitarian assistance.

In addition, we believe it is crucial to strengthen the role of the Peacebuilding Commission in making food security a key element of peacebuilding and peacekeeping, taking into account the specific characteristics of each country concerned and mobilizing the necessary efforts to that end.

Food security and the sustainability of food systems are priorities for Morocco at the national, regional international levels. Those priorities are at the heart of the South-South cooperation of Morocco with fraternal countries, in particular African countries, in accordance with the guidelines of His Majesty King Mohammed VI. At the initiative of His Majesty King Mohammed VI, Morocco launched, during the twenty-second Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (COP 22), held in Marrakesh, the initiative for the Adaptation of African Agriculture to Climate Change. Similarly, the Initiative on Sustainability, Stability and Security

is aimed at increasing the sustainability, stability and security of Africa through the vector of agriculture. There was also the African Action Summit on the sidelines of COP 22. Furthermore, three commissions on climate change have been established in Africa to combat climate change, which is the main driver of food insecurity. Morocco is providing policy, financial and technical support for the effective implementation of their important mandate.

Moreover, and in order to strengthening food security in Africa, Morocco has allocated millions of tons of fertilizer adapted to African soil and culture to the continent for several decades and has supported more than 44 million African farmers. In 2023, Morocco is allocating more than 4 million tons of fertilizer to African farmers, which is more than double what we did in 2021. And we are providing millions of tons of fertilizer to developing countries in other regions of the world.

Furthermore, Morocco is pursuing the implementation of its broad-scale programme to address food security in Africa through a scientific and holistic approach. Our efforts are aimed at mobilizing and aligning governmental resources, development partners and private sector funding to unleash Africa's food production potential through South-South and triangular cooperation with a view to ending food insecurity and thereby preventing potential conflicts.

In conclusion, Morocco reaffirms its full support to the Secretary-General in the implementation of the mandate of his Global Crisis Response Group on Food, Energy and Finance. We call for proactive international solidarity to put an end to the serious threats posed by hunger and food insecurity in a number of regions of the world, particularly in Africa.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of the Netherlands.

Ms. Brandt (Kingdom of the Netherlands): I would like to begin by congratulating you, Madam President, on assuming the presidency of the Security Council for the month of August, and thanking you for organizing this debate.

I have the honour to deliver this statement on behalf of the Benelux countries — Belgium, Luxembourg and my own country, the Kingdom of the Netherlands. We align ourselves with the statement delivered on behalf of the European Union.

The Benelux countries would like to stress the continued importance of resolution 2417 (2018), which we consider a landmark resolution, because it marked the first time the Council recognized the link between conflict and hunger. Today we reiterate the call for collective action and renewed commitment for its implementation. Sadly, as we heard from the briefers this morning, five years after the resolution's adoption, conflict continues to be the main driver of hunger and famine, with 70 per cent of the people facing food insecurity living in areas affected by conflict. Allow me to briefly touch on a couple of points.

First, in a context of ever-increasing conflict-induced humanitarian needs, we need to realize that this is a global challenge that we cannot leave to humanitarian organizations alone. We all have a responsibility to break the vicious cycle. Access restrictions in particular often pose obstacles to the effective delivery of humanitarian aid. Through resolution 2417 (2018), we have all committed to the prompt, safe and unimpeded delivery of assistance, in line with humanitarian principles. That includes allowing for a cross-border mechanism so that humanitarian aid can continue to reach those in need in Syria.

Secondly, resolution 2417 (2018) reminds us that under international humanitarian law, using the starvation of civilians as a method of warfare is unacceptable. While we underline that it is the primary responsibility of States to protect the populations on their territory, all parties to armed conflict have to respect international humanitarian law. Those responsible for violations must be held accountable, including through international mechanisms when national efforts fail. Member States can contribute to ensuring accountability by supporting the capabilities of human rights organizations and others to investigate violations of international humanitarian law related to conflict and hunger, and by ensuring that the importance of impartial investigations of allegations of hunger-related violations of international humanitarian law are reflected in resolutions such as those adopted by the Human Rights Council.

Thirdly, resolution 2417 (2018) calls on the Secretary-General to report to the Security Council when conflict may lead to acute food insecurity. It also commits Council members to acting on such reports. We urge the Council to step up its efforts in that regard. More frequent reporting and more action on the part of

the Council are vital if we are to seriously address the issue of conflict-induced hunger.

Finally, the destruction and deliberate targeting of agricultural land and infrastructure, such as we are now seeing in Ukraine, should stop. The effects on the civilian population and on global food prices and availability are devastating, particularly for the most vulnerable countries and people. It is therefore crucial for the Russian Federation to immediately return to the Black Sea Grain Initiative and end the war. For our part, the Benelux countries remain committed to supporting countries in combating food insecurity around the globe. Five years ago, we committed to breaking the cycle of conflict and hunger. It is now more important than ever that we live up to that commitment. It is a collective responsibility, and we count on Council members to hold us and themselves to it.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Ireland.

Mr. Gallagher (Ireland): I have the honour to deliver this statement on behalf of the Group of Friends of Action on Conflict and Hunger, co-chaired by Ireland and Ecuador.

We want to start by thanking the United States for once again convening a Security Council debate on this important issue. We also thank the briefers for their remarks. Their words serve to underline the need for all of us work together to counter the threat that conflict-induced hunger and famine pose to millions of people.

Despite the adoption five years ago of resolution 2417 (2018), the severity of conflict-induced hunger has only increased. Nearly 258 million people in 58 countries and territories experienced acute food insecurity in 2022. Women and girls are particularly affected by food insecurity, which exacerbates gender inequalities and risks of gender-based violence. Resolution 2417 (2018) requested the Secretary-General to swiftly report to the Council when "the risk of conflict-induced famine and widespread food insecurity occurs". That reporting serves as an early-warning mechanism. It assists the Council in responding to situations in which conflict- and violence-induced famine is an immediate danger and when lives could be saved if we acted quickly. As we meet today, there are numerous situations that meet that threshold.

In June, the Secretary-General, through the Emergency Relief Coordinator, made such a report, focusing on three situations. In Haiti, one in two people

were projected to face acute food insecurity by the end of June. In Burkina Faso, with 2.2 million people acutely food-insecure, including 22,500 risking starvation and death, the food security situation has never been worse. In the Democratic Republic of the Congo, 25.8 million people were projected to be acutely food-insecure by the end of June. Those are clearly more than just areas of concern. They are crises that merit an urgent response from the Council and the international community.

The Group of Friends appreciates that the Council did meet to discuss the contents of the most recent white note last week, in the format of an informal interactive dialogue. However, we believe it is essential for the Council to convene timely and open discussions. Open meetings can facilitate greater awareness of those crises and help mobilize support for the Council's efforts to address the country-specific recommendations of the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA). We welcomed resolution 2692 (2023) on Haiti, and we commend the co-penholders, Ecuador and the United States, as well as all members of the Council for including strong language on food security in the text, taking into account OCHA's update on food security risks in Haiti, in accordance with resolution 2417 (2018).

Those three country situations are part of a global emergency. Across the world, people's access to food is threatened by conflict and violence. As we heard from Ms. Ghelani this morning, conflict and violence increase the risk of hunger, especially in vulnerable areas where food systems are already under severe pressure from climate change, ecological degradation and extreme weather events, among other factors. We urge the Russian Federation to return to the Black Sea Grain Initiative to avoid even greater adverse impacts on global food security. It is high time for accelerated action by the Council, United Nations Member States and the international community. The Group of Friends, which was established to support and bolster the implementation of resolution 2417 (2018), would like to highlight three areas for action.

First, there should be renewed efforts by all Member States to respect international law, implement resolution 2417 (2018) and prevent conflict-induced hunger, including through greater support for locally and regionally led responses. That should also include a gendered response to food crises and increasing support for women's leadership in combating famine and building peace, in part through further support to women-led and women's rights organizations.

Secondly, we must work to ensure the sufficient, safe, rapid and unimpeded delivery of humanitarian assistance and civilians' access to critical services that they rely on for food security. The parties to conflicts must allow and facilitate humanitarian access to people in need, in line with their obligations under international law, in particular international humanitarian law and international human rights law, and accountability must be pursued for related violations. They include the use of starvation as a method of warfare and the destruction of objects indispensable to the survival of the civilian population. Such violations of international humanitarian law cannot be tolerated.

Thirdly, and most importantly, we must work at every level to encourage conflict prevention, conflict resolution and peacebuilding. Conflict is a leading driver of food insecurity and famine, and preventing conflict is the most effective way to prevent conflict-induced hunger. Ultimately, we need a renewed, sustained global effort to combat the deadly scourge of conflict-induced hunger, with Member States, humanitarian and development organizations, peacebuilders, civil society and others working together. The Group of Friends of Action on Conflict and Hunger will continue to do its part.

I will now say a few words in my national capacity. During Ireland's recent term on the Security Council, we urged the Council to do more in response to the increasing phenomenon of conflict-induced hunger. As co-focal points on conflict and hunger, we did so first with our colleagues from the Niger and then with Brazil, and I commend Brazil and Switzerland for continuing that important work. Yet far too often, when we sought to move the discussion from a theoretical one to seeking proactive Council action to prevent conflict-induced hunger in a particular country or region, we failed to receive the support we needed from other Council members. Many reasons were given, but it was ultimately a dereliction of the Council's duty as outlined in resolution 2417 (2018). Such intransigence on the part of the Council costs lives, and it continues.

Despite the dire food insecurity, with no end in sight, the Council finds itself having to meet behind closed doors when these issues are raised, and we feel that is unacceptable. If at an open debate we all lament conflict-induced hunger, if we say that starvation as a method of war is wrong and that it must not happen, the Security Council must do something about it when it has the opportunity. That means meeting in public and

taking measures as foreseen in resolution 2417 (2018). Fine words do not prevent conflicts, and they certainly do not fill bellies, but action can.

We saw that Council members can be extremely effective when they want to. The Council can come together. In 2016, following the Secretary-General's call to action to prevent four famines, the Council mobilized a global response, and that experience was a catalyst for the adoption of resolution 2417 (2018). Ireland remains committed to the conflict and hunger agenda and to the actions laid out by the Group of Friends of Action on Conflict and Hunger, and we hope that all members of the Council will do so too.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Singapore.

Mr. Gafoor (Singapore): Let me begin by congratulating the United States on assuming the presidency of the Security Council and commending it for convening today's debate on famine and conflict-induced global food insecurity. I would also like to thank Ms. Reena Ghelani and the other briefers for their very insightful briefings this morning.

The world is facing a critical moment in global food insecurity. More than 780 million people, or 10 per cent of the world's population, are experiencing hunger today, a proportion that remains above pre-pandemic levels. Intensifying global challenges, such as geopolitical conflicts in various parts of the world, climate change and economic volatility, have exacerbated food insecurity worldwide and contributed to rising food prices. Food security is an existential concern for many small countries and small island developing States, including island nations such as Singapore. Singapore is highly dependent on imported food. In fact, we import more than 90 per cent of the food that we consume. That means we are disproportionately affected by any disruptions in global food supply. The world needs urgent and collective action to address the global food crisis and to strengthen food systems' resilience, and in that regard I would like to make three points.

First, it is imperative that we keep global food supply chains free and open. That includes upholding the rules-based multilateral trading system, ensuring unimpeded movement of such essential items as food and agricultural commodities and refraining from imposing export prohibitions or restrictions in a manner inconsistent with the relevant provisions of the World Trade Organization.

Secondly, food security should not be politicized or weaponized. We must not allow the vicious cycle between conflict and hunger to be perpetuated. In that regard, we strongly support the Secretary-General's call for a resumption of the Black Sea Grain Initiative, including his commitment to facilitating unimpeded access to global food markets for food products and fertilizers from both Ukraine and the Russian Federation. We also call on all Member States not to politicize humanitarian aid and to ensure the safe and timely delivery of food assistance to people in need.

Thirdly, we need to invest in building sustainable and resilient global food systems. Food security is not merely a local or regional problem but a global challenge, because of our interdependence and because food crises can have spillover effects and broader implications. We therefore need to collectively invest in global food systems as a global public good, and to shift away from the mindset that the only way to address the issue is through aid. We should also address food insecurity as part of a broader ecological crisis that includes climate change, biodiversity loss and water scarcity. From enhancing supply-chain connectivity to developing new agrifood solutions, there are many areas where we can cooperate here at the United Nations.

Addressing the global food crisis requires collective responsibility and action. Singapore will continue to do its part, and we are prepared to work with all Member States, including the members of the Security Council, to strengthen collaboration and coordination in that regard.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Ukraine.

Ms. Hayovyshyn (Ukraine): I thank the United States presidency for convening this crucial debate and the briefers for their insightful contributions.

My delegation aligns itself with the statement delivered on behalf of the European Union and would like to highlight several key points on behalf of Ukraine.

Today's meeting of the Security Council is taking place amid the grave consequences of food insecurity, which poses a significant threat to international peace and security in multiple countries worldwide. During the United Nations Food Systems Summit+2 Stocktaking Moment on 24 July, the Secretary-General underscored the severity of the situation, saying that

“global food systems are broken — and billions of people are paying the price. More than 780 million people are going hungry while nearly one third of all food produced is lost or wasted”.

Recent data has shown that more than 250 million people faced acute food insecurity in 2022 and are in urgent need of food assistance. Countries such as Afghanistan, Haiti, Nigeria, Burkina Faso and Mali in the Sahel, Somalia, South Sudan, the Sudan and Yemen are particularly vulnerable, with populations likely to face starvation or death if immediate humanitarian intervention is not provided.

In November of last year, the President of Ukraine presented a 10-point peace formula, outlining the necessary steps for comprehensive, just and lasting peace for Ukraine and for global security. On 23 February, the General Assembly overwhelmingly adopted resolution ES-11/6, entitled “Principles of the Charter of the United Nations underlying a comprehensive, just and lasting peace in Ukraine”, which reflected the vision proposed in Ukraine’s peace formula. The initiative includes a specific point addressing food security, urging all Member States to cooperate in solidarity to address the global impacts of the war on food security.

Today’s discussion is particularly important, owing to Russia’s recent decision to terminate the Black Sea Grain Initiative, a move that will further exacerbate the global food crisis and directly affect the lives of tens of millions of people worldwide. In a single year under the Initiative, Ukraine exported 33 million tons of agricultural products to 45 countries, with 60 per cent of the volume going to countries in Africa and Asia. The figures would have been much higher if not for Russia’s systematic efforts to obstruct the Initiative’s normal functioning. Russia’s blockade of Ukraine’s food exports from Black Sea ports since February 2022 and its attacks on our farms and grain storage facilities have had severe effects in regions already struggling with food insecurity. The recent attacks on port infrastructure and civilian vessels have caused immense destruction, with approximately 220,000 tons of grain crops destroyed. The Russian Federation’s actions in Ukraine, along with its blackmail tactics, are strikingly reminiscent of the Holodomor, the genocide committed by Russia’s predecessor in Ukraine between 1932 and 1933. We appeal urgently to Member States to prevent the Russian Federation from causing famine in the world.

We are calling for support for Ukraine’s initiative to establish a humanitarian maritime corridor in the Black Sea, which will help re-establish vital food-supply routes to regions in dire need. We call on States to join the Grain from Ukraine humanitarian programme launched by President Zelenskyy, which has 34 States on board and has already raised \$200 million in donations and sent 170,000 tons of wheat to Ethiopia, Somalia, Yemen and Kenya. We must take appropriate measures to prevent the Russian Federation from using food as a weapon against the world. Ensuring the safety of navigation in the Black Sea is crucial to global food security. We must unite our efforts to combat hunger and prevent conflicts arising from food insecurity.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Slovakia.

Mr. Chatrnúch (Slovakia): At the outset, I would like to thank the United States for convening this timely and important meeting.

Our food systems are failing. Food prices in global markets have soared to their highest levels in three decades. Hundreds of millions of people go to bed hungry every day. Children are starving. The unequal impact of the imminent crisis is felt in developing countries, affecting the most vulnerable communities. We are witnessing the most devastating impacts in Haiti, Yemen, the Sudan, the Sahel region and elsewhere, while the international response is lagging behind. The World Food Programme recently announced the cutting of life-saving food programmes due to a chronic lack of funding. Despite its best efforts, it has found that is not currently possible to address the growing humanitarian needs around the world and meet the minimum recommended calories for all. We are leaving people in need behind, and the international community must act to reverse that trend.

The United Nations Food System Summit’s Stocktaking Moment, which took place last week in Rome, has underlined the need for urgent action on a global scale to tackle the unprecedented food crisis. Slovakia has reiterated its full support for transforming agricultural and food systems with a view to creating greater sustainability and resilience, specifically through Slovakia’s strategic plan for 2023–2027, the European Union’s Common Agricultural Policy and Slovakia’s vision for building modern agriculture for 2035. We remain committed to the implementation of Sustainable Development Goal 2 for zero hunger, and as part of the European Union, we are at the forefront

of combating food insecurity and malnutrition through funding and assistance.

Slovakia has co-signed the joint communiqué condemning the use of food as a weapon of war. In our view, that principle should be self-evident. The starvation of civilians as a method of war is a serious violation of international humanitarian law, and those who perpetrate it should be held accountable. Yet we are unfortunately witnessing the use of food as a weapon of war by a permanent member of the Security Council. For a long time, global food security has been under strain due to climate change and the pandemic. That dire situation has been further exacerbated by Russia's continuing war on Ukraine and its recent refusal to renew the Black Sea Grain Initiative. That deplorable act has put millions of people around the world at risk of malnutrition and famine due to disrupted production and supply chains. Let us not be fooled. Russia's subsequent symbolic handout of grain shipments to selected countries will not help to stabilize the crisis.

Lastly, we urge the Russian Federation to stop using food as a weapon, rejoin the Black Sea Grain Initiative without further delay and cease its illegal blocking of Ukrainian seaports. Hunger is both a consequence and a cause of conflict, and that vicious cycle can be broken only through international cooperation, respect for international law and enhanced solidarity.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Spain.

Ms. Jiménez de la Hoz (Spain) (*spoke in Spanish*): I join other delegations in congratulating you, Mr. President, on your assumption of the presidency of the Council this month. I wish you every success in the discharge of your responsibilities and thank you for convening this important debate on a crucial issue for the international community.

Spain aligns itself with the statement delivered on behalf of the European Union and would like to add some remarks in its national capacity.

We share the concern expressed by speakers throughout today's debate about the alarming increase in food insecurity, and consider that an urgent, coordinated and comprehensive response is needed to alleviate the suffering caused by food shortages. In that context, Spain condemns the decision of the Russian Federation to terminate the Black Sea Grain Initiative, which has played a crucial role in stabilizing and reducing food prices. We reiterate the call on Russia to

reconsider its decision and rejoin the initiative. Using hunger as a method of warfare undermines the four dimensions of food security — availability, access, utilization and stability — and constitutes a violation of international humanitarian law.

For our part, the criminal code in Spain punishes those who intentionally starve civilians as a method of warfare, while our recently approved humanitarian diplomacy strategy includes support for the implementation of resolution 2417 (2018), the promotion of multilateral and bilateral measures to prevent and prosecute acts that cause food insecurity in conflicts, and the promotion of the ratification of the amendment to the Rome Statute that criminalizes the intentional starvation of civilians in non-international conflicts as a crime under the jurisdiction of the International Criminal Court. To address food insecurity, in September 2022 Spain committed a total of €226.5 million for the next three years. In January 2023, an additional €14.4 million was approved for a shock plan against food insecurity by the World Food Programme, primarily in African countries.

Finally, we believe it is necessary to continue working on the triple nexus approach, ensuring respect for humanitarian principles and the quest for peaceful solutions to conflicts.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Indonesia.

Mr. Prabowo (Indonesia): I thank the United States for convening this meeting and all the briefers for their presentations.

It is truly concerning that armed conflict remains one of the most significant drivers of food insecurity, while the number of people affected continues to increase. The way in which conflict in one part of the world has affected millions of vulnerable people on the other side of the globe is equally concerning. Decisive and coordinated global actions need to be taken to ensure that food, a basic human right, is accessible and available to all. On that note, I would like to emphasize three points.

First, we must take concrete measures to break the vicious cycle between armed conflict, violence and food insecurity. The Security Council should work in synergy with other United Nations entities to address the root causes of conflict in order to sustain peace and achieve sustainable development. Indonesia urges all parties to conflicts to comply with international humanitarian

law and refrain from using famine as a weapon of war. Humanitarian workers, medical facilities and critical infrastructures, particularly those related to water, food and energy, must also be protected.

Secondly, we must enhance capacities and bolster resilience. Many countries are prone to global shocks such as rising food commodity prices, which have a greater impact in conflict areas. In the short term, people in those situations urgently need immediate assistance to survive, especially women and children. The international community must increase its support to humanitarian agencies to provide much-needed aid. Technical and financial assistance, as well as capacity-building, are also vital to achieving food security. In the medium and long term, greater investments, particularly for smallholder farmers, are required for more innovative, sustainable and resilient agriculture and food systems. In relation to the worsening impacts of climate change on food security, climate adaptation strategies also need to be taken into account.

Thirdly, we must strengthen international cooperation and multi-stakeholder collaboration. International efforts and coordinated actions among Governments, international organizations, the private sector and all relevant stakeholders must be synergized and avoid duplication. We primarily support the international efforts to keep food supply chains functioning under challenging circumstances. In our region the Association of Southeast Asian Nations, together with its dialogue partners, has also developed cooperation on food security and nutrition, including in times of crisis. We must continue to ensure the accessibility, affordability and sustainability of food and food products for those in need, particularly the vulnerable communities in developing and least-developed countries.

In view of the recent global dynamics, we regret that the Black Sea Grain Initiative and related measures are in limbo, interfering with the much-needed global supply of grain and fertilizers. Indonesia hopes to see the initiatives resumed and emphasizes that they should be implemented in their entirety and aimed at reaching those who need them the most — developing countries and the poor.

In conclusion, let me reaffirm Indonesia's commitment to contributing to and being part of the solution in addressing global food insecurity.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of the Republic of Korea.

Mr. Hwang (Republic of Korea): I would like to express our appreciation for the United States' leadership, Mr. President, in continuing to address the issue of conflict-driven food insecurity over the past three years. My gratitude also goes to the three briefers for their insightful presentations.

In the twentieth century, humankind dreamed of a world in which no one suffered from hunger, thanks to modern science and agricultural technologies. To our dismay, however, that dream has not been realized. As articulated in resolution 2417 (2018) and noted in this year's report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/345) on the protection of civilians in armed conflict, the devastating impacts of armed conflict on food security require urgent action on the part of the international community. In that regard, my delegation welcomed the Security Council's adoption of presidential statement S/PRST/2023/4 this morning and is pleased to join the joint communiqué condemning the use of food as a weapon of war. We also call for the extension of the Black Sea Grain Initiative, through which 32 million tons of grain were released to the global market over the past year.

We note with grave concern that climate change is exacerbating both conflict and food insecurity. The Council should facilitate thorough climate-risk assessments and call for climate-informed early warning, prevention and peacebuilding in vulnerable environments. Those compounding effects are especially concerning for Africa, which has also felt the biggest impact from the increase in food prices since the war on Ukraine began. The Republic of Korea has pledged to double its rice aid to Africa to 100,000 tons a year. And in May, at the Group of Seven Summit, President Yoon Suk Yeol announced the K-Ricebelt project, designed to help African countries produce rice locally. After its completion five years from now, the project is expected to continue to provide rice to 30 million people in eight African countries.

I would like to take this opportunity to highlight the serious food insecurity that exists in another part of the world, where the situation is no less grave than in areas of conflict. The long-standing acute and chronic food shortages in the Democratic People's Republic of Korea have recently deteriorated further. And that food crisis is unquestionably regime-induced, the result of three wrong choices — nuclear and missile development, the

closure of the border and a market-distorting policy. The Democratic People's Republic of Korea has wasted its scarce resources, which have exploded vainly in the skies thanks to the unprecedented scale and frequency of its missile launches over the past year and a half, 12 of them intercontinental ballistic-missile launches. According to some estimates, the resources expended on them would have been enough to cover the country's annual food shortfall last year.

Moreover, the coronavirus disease pandemic provided a pretext for sealing off the border, thereby curbing access for the United Nations and international humanitarian assistance to the people of North Korea. Late last year, the Democratic People's Republic of Korea adopted a new policy banning private commerce in grains, with the aim of tightening central control over food distribution. That has exacerbated hunger among ordinary North Koreans, who, except for the top brass, have relied on local private markets for food, because the State distribution system has not functioned since the mid-1990s. I feel obliged to bring the issue to the attention of the global community, because I am seeing our Korean brothers and sisters across the border suffering from chronic and human-made food shortages.

We need to remember that it is innocent, ordinary people who endure the brunt of food insecurity, whether conflict- or regime-induced. As an elected member of the Security Council starting next year, the Republic of Korea looks forward to actively contributing to the Council's noble endeavours to maintain international peace and security, including the critical issue of food security.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Romania.

Ms. Mocanu (Romania): I thank the United States for convening this debate and the briefers for their insights. I also wish you success, Mr. President, in implementing the objectives of your presidency, which has just begun. Let me also inform you that Romania did not hesitate to join the communiqué proposed by the United States condemning the use of food as a weapon of war. It is consistent with our strong belief that food must not be used as a weapon of war. Depriving individuals of their right to food is against international law, deeply unethical and an illegal tactic that inflicts further suffering on civilians.

The recently published report on *The State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World* notes that one in five people in Africa are going hungry in 2023. It also notes that almost 600 million will be chronically undernourished by 2030, which is 23 million more than there would have been if Russia's war against Ukraine had not happened. Not only has the war shaken important pillars of the global food system, it has disrupted supply chains, raising the cost of energy and fuelling inflation, especially in the import-dependent countries of Africa and Asia. After Russia's withdrawal from the Black Sea Grain Initiative last month, grain prices rose to their highest levels since the beginning of the war.

In the past 10 days we have witnessed aggressive actions by Russia designed to disrupt grain exports to third countries by targeting port infrastructure on the Danube, close to Romania's territory. But the civilian ports on the Danube River have a special mission at this moment in history — to provide alternative ways to export grains from Ukraine to the world and to ensure the safety of ships and their crews. Since the very first hours of the bombing of Ukrainian ports on 25 July, and consistent with our stance on Ukrainian refugees, we have allowed boats on the Danube River to seek shelter at Romanian ports to save their crews' lives and safeguard their cargoes. What is unfolding is a global humanitarian crisis, and it requires all of our attention. Romania has facilitated the export of more than 20 million tons of grain from Ukraine to the world, in addition to the 32 million tons that were shipped via the Black Sea Grain Initiative. But we need to return to the spirit of the Initiative if we are truly committed to leaving no one behind.

Food prices are now skyrocketing. Wars and conflicts are one of the causes. The other is climate change, which is having a visible impact on the soil and people's lives. We see it in the Horn of Africa, sub-Saharan Africa, the Middle East and, increasingly, the northern hemisphere. It is a threat that cannot be overlooked. After last week's Food Systems Summit Stocktaking Moment, and in anticipation of the Sustainable Development Goal Summit to be held in September, action is needed more than ever. We cannot afford to simply stand by and watch a vicious cycle in which food supplies are deliberately disrupted or destroyed, agricultural lands ravaged and access to vital resources blocked. Present and future generations, particularly vulnerable civilians — children, including the very young, women and the elderly — will endure

starvation, malnutrition and even famine. We need to redouble our efforts to avoid a global humanitarian crisis before it is too late to save lives. And we need to act in accordance with international law with regard to secure food delivery, unrestricted access for aid workers and funding.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Burkina Faso.

Mr. Ganou (Burkina Faso) (*spoke in French*): First of all, allow me to thank the United States for giving us the opportunity to take part in today's open debate of the Security Council on famine- and conflict-induced global food insecurity. I commend this morning's briefers for their excellent briefings, which describe a troubling situation that requires action.

In Burkina Faso, a combination of structural factors linked to climate, poverty and external shocks has been undermining livelihoods, with concurrent sporadic famines, for a long time now. The worsening of food insecurity over the past few years is due, to a large extent, to the security crisis. Terrorist attacks have indeed caused a humanitarian crisis that has displaced approximately 2 million people — nearly 80 per cent of whom are women and children — and led to the confiscation of arable land and livestock. Terrorists have also attempted to brazenly prevent the regular delivery of food and medicine to areas facing major security challenges.

Given the difficult security and food situation, in the spirit of recovery and resilience, Burkina Faso adopted the Stabilization and Development Action Plan 2023–2025, which has the following priorities: to combat terrorism, restore territorial integrity, address the humanitarian crisis, rebuild the State and improve governance, and, lastly, strive for national reconciliation and social cohesion. To support that Action Plan, the United Nations system and the transitional Government have agreed on the United Nations Interim Action Plan for Sustainable Development 2023–2025, the goals of which are aligned with the Government's priorities.

At the operational level, concerning efforts to combat food insecurity, since 2012, Burkina Faso and its partners have been developing and implementing a plan to respond to and support populations at risk of food insecurity and malnutrition. The 2023 response plan, adopted in May and which will cost \$357 million, now has a financial shortfall of nearly \$161 million. In addition to the plan, a presidential

initiative for agricultural production was also adopted in May. It set the goal for 190,000 tons of grain to be produced between 2003 and 2024, for a total cost of approximately \$35 million. The plan is aimed at meeting national grain demand and preparing for the return of combatants and internally displaced persons to jobs in agriculture once territorial integrity is restored. Off-season crops, the distribution of fertilizer and the agricultural mechanization programme are all initiatives that require the efforts of all stakeholders in our fight against food insecurity.

In conclusion, allow me to add the following recommendations to our debate. It is crucial to ensure improved coordination among the various stakeholders in order to support national initiatives, as mentioned earlier, and regional initiatives, and to do so in a timely manner. With regard to regional initiatives, the Economic Community of West African States has specific mechanisms and agencies for that purpose, including the Regional Agency for Agriculture and Food and the Regional Food Security Reserve. Support for those initiatives should allow for the development of more resilient and sustainable agriculture on the one hand and, on the other, for food stocks to be brought closer to those in need, while taking into account their dietary habits by supplying them with local products.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Bangladesh.

Mr. Muhith (Bangladesh): We warmly congratulate the delegation of the United States on assuming the presidency of the Security Council for the month of August. We welcome the convening of today's timely debate and thank the briefers for their valuable remarks.

The global food security landscape, a critical component of overall human security, has been significantly affected by conflict and climate change in recent years. Bangladesh is no exception. The ongoing war in Ukraine and related sanctions and counter-sanctions have severely affected our import bills and therefore jeopardized our efforts to ensure food security for the 168 million people of Bangladesh. Yet, we are trying our best to tackle the challenges, including through difficult policy measures, such as withdrawing subsidies in the energy sector, limiting imports and reducing public expenditure. As long-term measures, we have prioritized investments in agrifood systems. Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina has encouraged all to cultivate unused lands in every household.

At the international level, we support all global efforts in addressing food insecurity. As one of the Champions of the Secretary-General's Global Crisis Response Group, our Prime Minister is advocating for and facilitating global consensus on actions to prevent, mitigate and respond to the food crisis and related challenges.

Given the systemic nature of the crisis, we need collective endeavours. Allow me to highlight four specific points in that regard.

First, it is essential to address factors that affect food prices and access, especially during conflict. We support the Secretary-General's call to keep markets open, remove unnecessary export restrictions and release food reserves to improve the food supply. It is also critical to keep the Black Sea Grain Initiative alive. Equally important is to continue strengthening diplomatic efforts to end wars — the very cause of human suffering.

Secondly, we denounce the use of famine and starvation as weapons of war, which are prohibited by the 1977 Protocols Additional to the Geneva Conventions. Furthermore, the Rome Statute recognizes such actions as a direct violation of international law, constituting crimes against humanity. We call upon all Member States to remain committed to those obligations. We also call upon parties to armed conflict to refrain from attacking critical infrastructure that is essential for the production, distribution and transport of food.

Thirdly, climate change and related disasters have serious impacts on food security. To address those impacts, we have implemented various innovative agricultural practices. In the past 14 years, our scientists have developed 690 improved and high-yielding crop varieties, including salinity-tolerant rice varieties. We are now working on drought and submergence-tolerant varieties.

It is critical to further invest in those sectors. We reiterate our call for international cooperation, including South-South cooperation, climate financing and technology transfer, to support vulnerable countries such as Bangladesh. The development of a food stockholding mechanism for the least developed countries, as stipulated in the Doha Programme of Action, should also be pursued seriously.

Finally, Bangladesh is also affected by the endless conflicts and insecurity in Myanmar. For the past six years, we have been hosting more than 1.2 million

Rohingyas who have fled persecution and violence in Myanmar. However, due to multiple humanitarian emergencies, the United Nations and other humanitarian partners are now facing funding shortfalls in supporting the Rohingyas sheltered in Bangladesh. The World Food Programme has had to implement rations cuts twice. As mentioned by Secretary Blinken earlier today, a Rohingya receives only 27 cents a day for food intake. That dire situation is leading to malnutrition, insecurity and violence in the camps.

We call upon the Council to pay urgent attention to the lingering conflict in Myanmar and help to create an environment conducive to the safe and sustainable repatriation of the Rohingyas. The international community must also continue providing adequate funding to the humanitarian response plan for displaced Rohingyas until they are able to return to Myanmar.

In conclusion, I wish to flag the need for addressing food waste as a crucial aspect of global food insecurity and call for building a broad-based social movement to prevent that.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Argentina.

Mr. Mainero (Argentina) (*spoke in Spanish*): At the outset, my delegation would like to congratulate the United States on its assumption of the presidency of the Security Council and thank it for convening this important open debate.

According to the World Food Programme, 60 per cent of the people suffering from hunger throughout the world live in conflict zones. The most recent report of the Secretary-General on the protection of civilians in armed conflict (S/2023/345) underscores the fact that conflict and insecurity were the most significant drivers of high levels of acute food insecurity for approximately 117 million people in 19 countries and territories. Armed conflicts generate food insecurity by destroying farms, roads and ports, paralysing the economy and disrupting humanitarian access. Food insecurity, in turn, can become a trigger for violence and migration-related instability and a factor in recruitment by terrorist groups.

In recent years, the Security Council has focused on the link between conflict and hunger. In 2018, the Council adopted resolution 2417 (2018), which recalls the link between armed conflict and conflict-induced food insecurity. Resolution 2417 (2018) strongly condemns the use of the starvation of civilians as

a method of warfare and the unlawful denial of humanitarian access. And it urges all parties to protect critical civilian infrastructure to ensure the proper functioning of food systems.

The Secretary-General's report highlights that, four years after the adoption of resolution 2417 (2018), armed conflict continued to be a primary driver of hunger.

International humanitarian law prohibits using the starvation of civilians as a method of warfare and provides protection for objects necessary to provide food and drinking water. Despite those provisions of international humanitarian law, hunger is, with alarming frequency, the consequence of armed conflicts, either because the belligerents deliberately use it in violation of their obligations or because it arises as an indirect consequence of the destruction caused by war. What is clear is that respect for the rules of international humanitarian law can help to mitigate the impact of armed conflicts on food security.

Argentina, as a global producer and supplier of healthy, nutritious and quality food, is committed to ending hunger and achieving global food security in compliance with the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, in particular Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) 2. We believe that the long food supply chains inherent to open international trade play a key role in guaranteeing and supporting global food security and the achievement of the SDGs in humanitarian emergency situations or armed conflicts.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Panama.

Ms. Concepción Jaramillo (Panama) (*spoke in Spanish*): We congratulate the United States on its assumption of the presidency of the Security Council for the month of August.

Constructive political will in accordance with international law, frank dialogue without conditions to achieve peace, sustainable development and respect for human rights are key pillars of Panama's foreign policy.

We call for revitalized multilateralism as a tool to prevent aggression and violations of international peace and security, prioritizing joint action and commitments aimed at addressing the consequences of conflicts, the adverse situations of climate change and gender inequality.

Panama reiterates the importance of implementing all viable measures to ensure the protection of all

civilians who are victims of the war in Ukraine, meeting their basic needs and facilitating the rapid and unimpeded passage of humanitarian aid to all people living with the consequences of the armed conflict, with a view to guaranteeing international humanitarian law.

We join Secretary-General António Guterres in expressing our disappointment at the Russian Federation's unilateral withdrawal from the Black Sea Grain Initiative. We urge it to reverse that decision and to re-establish negotiations to keep open the Black Sea humanitarian corridor, which guarantees the functioning of the agricultural system. That will have a positive impact on the most vulnerable people in developing countries, who currently spend more than 50 per cent of their income to cover the high costs of food and energy.

It is time to address the specific nutrition needs of women and children to promote and protect the right to food and accelerate the transformation to more egalitarian, gender-sensitive and sustainable food systems. Evidence shows that greater participation of women at all levels of decision-making is essential to assure and maintain peace.

In situations of conflict and food insecurity, women and girls are more likely to experience gender-based violence. In addition, those situations may force women and girls to engage in transactional sex, that is, to exchange sex for food or money to buy food.

Five years ago, the Council adopted resolution 2417 (2018), which noted the link between armed conflict and violence, on one hand, and conflict-related food insecurity, on the other. The food insecurity situation was already critical before the outbreak of the conflict and had worsened as a result of the coronavirus disease pandemic. War and all its impacts have deepened a global cost-of-living crisis not seen in at least a generation, compromising our aspirations for a better world by 2030. Council members must pay particular attention to ensuring compliance with international law, especially in cases of maintaining international peace and security.

Panama clearly and unequivocally reaffirms that hunger can never be used as a weapon of war.

Panama supports the Secretary-General's proposal for a New Agenda for Peace. Better collaboration among all the principal organs of the United Nations is essential to address the structural causes of conflicts and prevent them with a comprehensive vision.

Panama believes in dialogue and negotiation as indispensable ways to achieve peace, through respect for international law and the principles that underpin it. To that end, it is essential to reaffirm solidarity as one of the essential values for the twenty-first century.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Sierra Leone.

Mr. Kpukumu (Sierra Leone): The delegation of Sierra Leone congratulates the United States of America on its assumption of the presidency of the Security Council for August and on its organization of this high-level open debate on famine and conflict-induced global food insecurity.

On his recent re-election for a second term, His Excellency President Julius Maada Bio has committed his Government to five key priorities, with addressing food insecurity as the flagship. With the election of Sierra Leone as a non-permanent member of the Security Council for 2024 to 2025, we look forward to effectively working with other members of Council to tackle food insecurity. We all share a fundamental responsibility to take action to create a world free from hunger, because food insecurity is both a consequence and a driver of global instability.

World hunger is an issue of global concern. A combination of factors, namely famine, the effects of armed conflicts, climate change and global inequalities have become leading causes of food insecurity in our world and have driven millions of people to the brink of starvation. That scenario is characterized by unprecedented numbers of people displaced by conflict, catastrophic weather events and natural disasters.

Many people cannot afford enough food owing to famine or conflict. It is estimated that about 70 per cent of food insecure countries are also considered fragile. According to the *2023 Global Report on Food Crises* in West Africa and the Sahel and parts of Central Africa, the levels of acute food insecurity during the June to August lean season are projected to be the highest on record, driven by worsening conflict and insecurity, particularly in the central Sahel and the Lake Chad basin areas. Other instances have been characterized by increased economic shocks, including widespread inflation and currency depreciation. In view of prioritizing its food security, the Government of Sierra Leone has an eight-point plan, including increasing food production, cash-crop production and livestock production, investing in agriculture, improving

governance, research in the agricultural sector and water management, and establishing at least three agri-processing zones.

Conflict remains a crucial driver of food insecurity and malnutrition and represents one of the most significant hindrances to fulfilling the right to food. Conflicts negatively affect the entire food system, exacerbate the ill-affordability of healthy diets and seriously threaten global efforts to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals, including eradicating hunger and malnutrition by 2025. Although the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations has indicated that rapid reduction in need is possible, it is clear that reaching those goals may be challenging to achieve, especially when countries are affected by conflicts and political instability.

The world must listen, find ways to prevent and address hunger crises and advocate for greater humanitarian access to needy communities. Ensuring food security everywhere should be a central issue for every Member State of the United Nations, most especially the members of the Security Council. Our actions must not lead to the disruption of food systems and the aggravation of hunger, because food insecurity produces instability, as both are intricately connected. In that vein, we urge the continued constructive engagement of all the relevant parties to secure the continuation of the Black Sea Grain Initiative — sustaining that deal is important to prevent a further increase in food prices and a worsening of the global food crisis.

In conclusion, it is important to note that climate change, desertification and imbalances in global trade are interconnected challenges that the world faces today. Climate change is causing more extreme weather events, with multiple impacts, including desertification. Desertification, in turn, is making it difficult to grow food, which is contributing to food insecurity and global hunger. The imbalance in global trade and access to development finance are also major challenges that, in turn, deepen poverty and inequality in many countries. Reforming the international financial institutions, among other things, is essential to address those challenges. The international financial institutions, such as the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund, have a major role to play in financing climate mitigation and adaptation and in supporting the Sustainable Development Goals.

Finally, my delegation commends Secretary-General António Guterres for his sustained dedication and commitment to achieving a food-secure world, and the Government of Italy, for its leadership in hosting the first United Nations Food Systems Stocktaking Moment.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of the Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela.

Mr. Poveda Brito (Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela) (*spoke in Spanish*): The Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela has the honour of speaking on behalf of the Group of Friends in Defence of the Charter of the United Nations. I will deliver a shortened version of my statement, the full version of which will be provided to the Secretariat.

The Universal Declaration of Human Rights and article 11 of the International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights recognize the right of everyone to an adequate standard of living, including adequate food. Consequently, and with respect for the provisions of international human rights law, we consider the right to food and the right of everyone to be free from hunger an inalienable human right of every human being. I therefore take this opportunity to reiterate, at the outset of my statement, the firm commitment of the States members of the Group of Friends to sparing no effort to end hunger, achieve food security, improve nutrition and promote sustainable agriculture, in line with our relevant international commitments, including those derived from the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, and our respective national programmes in that field.

It is no secret that the world is currently experiencing a multifaceted crisis, and that food insecurity is indeed one of the facets of that global crisis. That reality has now been exacerbated, not only by the worst pandemic humankind has faced in the past century, but also by the ongoing climate catastrophe, growing inequalities and conflicts, including those of a protracted nature, among other things. There is, however, yet another element that has and continues to deliberately exacerbate famine, hunger and food insecurity at the local, national, regional and international levels, as even recognized recently by the World Health Organization — that is, the continued, systematic and relentless promulgation, application and even expansion of unilateral coercive measures.

Such measures, which are cruel, inhumane and have no legal basis within the scope of the purposes and principles of the Charter of the United Nations,

are an affront to the right to food and development, among other things. They clearly seek, among others, to deprive entire populations of their own means of subsistence, in flagrant violation of the most basic norms of international law. In addition, they are included in the toolbox used by certain Governments to advance their national interests and dubious agendas abroad. Instrumentalizing the economy and the international financial system to take action against others, particularly through the application of unilateral coercive measures — which, as facts demonstrate, can be as lethal as weapons used in conventional warfare — is one of the means used to induce, escalate and prolong conflicts worldwide.

Let us be clear — given their wide scope, extraterritorial implications and systemic nature, unilateral coercive measures are deliberately exacerbating the multifaceted crisis humankind is facing today and will continue to not only negatively affect the global economy as a whole, but also cause and prolong human suffering around the world, unless they are completely eliminated, which would enable every nation, without discrimination or limitation of any sort, to fully pursue its productive potential and, in turn, to contribute to overcoming the current challenges, including through the stabilization of certain commodity prices, including of food and fertilizers.

Moreover, the continued application of unilateral coercive measures makes it nearly impossible for nations subjected to them to purchase equipment, software, hardware and spare parts and to ensure the proper technology transfers needed for the development and production of the agricultural and agri-food industry, among other things. As I mentioned before, such measures also have extraterritorial implications and an impact on other nations, some of which have opted to reduce legal trade with nations subjected to those measures for fear of being subjected to secondary sanctions, as mentioned in the Global Report on Food Crises 2023. It is a reality that has ultimately further exacerbated the current global food insecurity crisis.

We agree with the assertion included in the concept note prepared for today's open debate (S/2023/560, annex) that global food insecurity is a generational challenge, and we must aim for an ambitious goal to rid the world of famine.

An initial — and perhaps the simplest — step in that direction would be putting an end once and for all to unilateral coercive measures, which currently

affect over 30 countries around the world, many of which are part of our Group of Friends, and which are not only ready but have the potential to make a major contribution to our common endeavour, including in the production and export of grains and fertilizers, among others. In that regard, we cannot overemphasize the fact that all parties must commit equally to being part of the solution, given that we are more than able and willing to do our part and to be reliable and responsible suppliers of commodities, goods and services, for the well-being of our peoples and of all humankind.

The solution to that generational challenge hinges on the urgent adoption of collective strategies and decisive measures that must necessarily be rooted in the purposes and principles of the Charter of the United Nations. We do not need humanitarian interventions, as mentioned in the concept note for this meeting (S/2023/560, annex). What we need instead is greater cooperation, capacity-building and solidarity, as well as an expansion and deepening of South-South, North-South and triangular cooperation, with a view to strengthening national capacities. We must emphasize, however, that any kind of assistance in that area, particularly if it is humanitarian in nature, must strictly adhere to the guiding principles for the provision of humanitarian assistance, as outlined in General Assembly resolution 46/182, and must have the consent of the concerned State.

We conclude by stressing that the way to successfully address and overcome the current challenges that humanity as a whole is facing — including with regard to famine, hunger and food insecurity — is neither the continued application or the expansion of unilateral coercive measures, nor the imposition of unjustified and arbitrary trade restrictions, including tariff and non-tariff barriers. Rather, it is the adoption of joint, effective, inclusive and innovative measures that, in strict adherence to the tenets of the Charter of the United Nations and the norms of international law, allow us, all together, to overcome the present multifaceted crisis that — whether as a result of scarcity or of inflation — threatens us all equally today, particularly hundreds of millions of people in the developing world. It is our moral responsibility to present and future generations to correct our course and to do so now.

Lastly, as many have said today in this room, food must indeed never be used as a weapon of war. Similarly, we also emphasize that unilateral coercive measures, including fourth-generation measures, must never be

used as a tactic of warfare, for the purpose of inflicting starvation, or to exterminate entire peoples, including by depriving them of access to food as a direct result of resorting to such illegal, cruel and inhumane measures.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Latvia.

Mr. Pildegovičs (Latvia): I would like to thank the United States for organizing this open debate and the briefers for their statements. Latvia also commends the United States for presenting the joint communiqué condemning the use of food as a weapon of war. Latvia has joined the signatories of that document.

Latvia aligns itself with the statement delivered by the representative of the European Union.

The staggering number of people who are food-insecure keeps increasing, reaching record levels. The growing number of armed conflicts in different geographic areas is alarming. The Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations and the World Food Programme are both warning us of acute food insecurity being likely to deteriorate even further in 18 hunger hotspots around the world. Somalia, Yemen, Afghanistan, Haiti, Burkina Faso, Mali, South Sudan, the Sudan and Nigeria are at the highest concern level.

The Security Council unanimously adopted resolution 2417 (2018) five years ago, but we have yet to succeed in breaking the vicious cycle of armed conflict and food insecurity. Five years later, one of the permanent members of the Council, namely, the Russian Federation, is deliberately deepening food insecurity and significantly adding to the suffering of the most vulnerable people across the globe. By invading Ukraine and weaponizing food, and through destroying Ukraine's agricultural lands, crippling its agricultural economy and blocking its exports, Russia has disrupted grain deliveries worldwide and fuelled a surge in food prices globally.

Given the central role of Ukraine in the global food supply chain, the Black Sea Grain Initiative has been critical to addressing the heightened food crisis caused by Russia's war of aggression against Ukraine. However, most regrettably, Russia has taken further steps to push more people into poverty, hunger and starvation. We condemn Russia's decision to terminate its participation in the Black Sea Grain Initiative and the subsequent barrage of attacks on Ukrainian port facilities and agricultural warehouses, which have destroyed tens of thousands of tons of foodstuff. Russia

has gone so far as to declare that it will consider any cargo ships traveling to Ukraine's Black Sea ports to be a military target. Such actions highlight Russia's willingness and intention to employ food as a weapon of war, rather than an essential humanitarian commodity to prevent starvation and hunger around the globe. The Russian Federation must immediately cease its unlawful military activities to ensure the resumption of shipments of food and agricultural commodities to and from Ukraine.

Disruptions in the agricultural market are easily avoidable, and the international system based on international law, including the Charter of the United Nations, must not tolerate deliberate attacks on global agricultural supply chains and global food markets. We need quick and decisive action to ensure that the supply of food is available when it is needed the most and to minimize the effects of conflicts on food security. That includes unhampered humanitarian access to effectively address growing humanitarian needs and the threat of famine in armed conflicts.

It is crucial that the international community mobilize under the United Nations leadership to respond to the food, energy and financial crisis exacerbated by Russia's war. We commend the efforts of the Secretary-General, António Guterres, and the United Nations agencies that are at the forefront of fighting food insecurity and ensuring the continuous flow of foodstuff. In the meantime, there is a great need for continuous efforts to build up resilient and sustainable agricultural and food systems and reliable supply chains. That endeavour is ever more critical in a post-pandemic world that needs to adapt to the adverse impacts of climate change, which poses new risks and can therefore further reinforce the vicious cycle of conflict and food insecurity. Latvia will continue to support multilateral efforts to address those challenges and to share our know-how with developing countries, including smart solutions for sustainable agriculture and water management.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of South Africa.

Mr. Mnguni (South Africa): My delegation would like to congratulate the United States of America on presiding over the work of the Council for the month of August and to convey our best wishes of success during its presidency. We thank you, Sir, for convening this high-level open debate on a critical topic. We also thank the briefers for their insightful presentations.

We witness with deep concern and dismay the rising number of people who are acutely food-insecure and who require urgent food assistance. That is a reality faced by the African continent owing to various factors, including protracted conflicts, climate vulnerability, weather extremes, soaring food and energy prices, the coronavirus disease and economic slowdowns.

South Africa is concerned by the destabilization of global peace and security, in particular the emergence of new conflicts and the lack of resolution of protracted conflicts, which affect women and children disproportionately and which contribute to worsening the global humanitarian crisis. Addressing the root causes of conflict and the drivers of food insecurity in conflict settings remains at the centre of the solutions we ought to pursue. We cannot overemphasize the importance of coordinated global efforts to prevent conflicts and the imperative need to pursue political settlements to existing conflicts. Peaceful dialogue and negotiations are the bedrock of international peace and security. It is in that context that South Africa is part of the initiative of African leaders to pursue a peaceful resolution of the conflict between Russia and Ukraine.

South Africa is deeply concerned that, in some conflict situations, starvation is used as a tactic of warfare in contravention of international humanitarian law. Parties to conflict should not use starvation or the threat of starvation as a weapon of warfare. We therefore urge States and parties to conflict to fulfil their responsibilities on the protection of civilians and ensure unimpeded access to humanitarian assistance for those in need. This open debate offers Member States the opportunity to renew our commitment to uphold international law and act in accordance with the principles of international humanitarian law.

This open debate is timely. It reminds us of our core obligations to mitigate and alleviate hunger in armed conflict situations. Hunger and starvation are occurring in the context of a 13 per cent increase in global military expenditure. That is immoral and reminds us that the use of force is never wise. The nexus between development and peace necessitates that we adopt a comprehensive approach to issues of international peace and security. In 2015, we all adopted the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development (General Assembly resolution 70/1) and proclaimed the eradication of poverty and ending of hunger as an overarching goal. Unfortunately, current data indicates that the world is falling off-track with regard to the

achievement of the Sustainable Development Goals by 2030. If we do not redouble and better target our efforts, our goal of ending hunger, food insecurity and malnutrition in all its forms by 2030 will remain out of reach.

If we are to achieve our goals, we need a multilateral system that will be able to strengthen mechanisms of prevention for a world that is peaceful. We also need to invest resources and strengthen our confidence in the Rome-based agencies, such as the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations, the World Food Programme and the International Fund for Agricultural Development, which are centre-stage when it comes to building capacity and resilient food systems.

In conclusion, there is an urgent need for humanitarian intervention in countries in crisis to provide effective social protection measures. This will include improved food security and nutrition for populations in need and protect livelihoods. It is also vital that the Security Council and Member States make concerted efforts to implement resolution 2417 (2018), addressing food insecurity and the threat of famine as a consequence of armed conflict.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Estonia.

Ms. Lõuk (Estonia): I thank you, Mr. President, for convening this important open debate. I thank the briefers for their valuable input.

Estonia aligns itself with the statement delivered by the representative of the European Union earlier today.

Global food security has continued to worsen in recent years. According to the United Nations, 258 million people in 58 countries faced acute food insecurity in 2022 owing to climate change, armed conflicts and the effects of the coronavirus disease pandemic. The World Food Programme estimates that those numbers have continued to grow this year.

The implementation of resolution 2417 (2018) remains highly relevant, as 70 per cent of the world's hungry people live in areas afflicted by war and violence. The Democratic Republic of the Congo, the Horn of Africa, Afghanistan, Yemen and Syria are just some of the places facing famine due to armed conflicts. Hunger tends to create vicious cycles that lead to new conflicts and hinder any possible progress.

In that context, it is shameful that a key United Nations-facilitated initiative to improve global food

security — the Black Sea Grain Initiative — was unilaterally abandoned by a permanent member of the Council. Russia's selfish and cynical decision to weaponize food by terminating the implementation of the Black Sea Grain Initiative is a catastrophic loss for people in need everywhere. The Initiative kept global food prices stable and enabled 33 million tons of Ukrainian wheat to reach 45 countries across the globe, with 65 per cent of exports going to developing countries.

As the world is thinking of ways to continue Ukrainian food exports, Russia has further escalated its war against food by bombing Ukrainian granaries and food export facilities. Just yesterday, it bombed the Izmail port on the river Danube, destroying 40,000 tons of grain destined for countries in Africa, China and Israel and increasing global wheat prices by 4 per cent. Furthermore, Russia has attacked Ukrainian energy infrastructure, which powers the agricultural sector, and is threatening all vessels heading to and from Ukrainian ports. The recent decision by Russia to offer a small amount of free grain to six African Member States is yet another attempt by Russia to create a false illusion of its capabilities to replace Ukrainian grain. As the Secretary-General stated, it is not a handful of donations to some countries that will correct the dramatic impacts affecting everyone, everywhere.

Estonia supports the United Nations in trying to salvage the Black Sea Grain Initiative, which had been a functioning solution to a problem Russia itself created by invading Ukraine. We call upon Russia to stop its war against Ukraine.

Estonia is committed to helping those regions in most desperate need. We have contributed additional humanitarian aid to the Horn of Africa and Yemen this year, and our regular contributions to the World Food Programme, the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, the Central Emergency Response Fund, UNICEF and the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees help to respond to humanitarian crises globally. Let me also recall the European Union's solidarity lanes initiative, which has helped to export 41 million tons of food from Ukraine.

In conclusion, the global community must do better and hold to account those actors who are using starvation as a method of warfare and violating international humanitarian law. Estonia remains a committed partner to the United Nations in tackling global hunger and addressing its root causes.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Israel.

Mr. Miller (Israel): We wish to thank Secretary Blinken and the United States delegation for initiating this high-level debate, reinforcing the critical importance of combating food insecurity.

As a nation in the Middle East, Israel experienced food insecurity throughout the first decades of its existence but managed to transform challenges into opportunities. Harnessing resilience and innovation led us to great advancements in agricultural and water management technologies. Our goal is not only to make a difference on a national level — we also seek to make a global impact, and we do so through cooperation both bilaterally and multilaterally. Just last year, the General Assembly once again adopted the biannual Israeli-initiated resolution on agricultural technology (General Assembly resolution 76/200). The resolution promotes the use of technology and research and development to increase agricultural productivity and food security.

We are firm believers in regional cooperation as a means of combating the root causes of food insecurity. Our commitment is evident from our collaboration with Morocco on water security, our joint water desalination and solar energy deal with Jordan, facilitated by the United Arab Emirates, and many more projects with our neighbours. The recent conference of the N7 Initiative on agriculture, water and food security in Abu Dhabi displayed the universality of the challenges we face.

However, we must acknowledge that food insecurity is not solely a result of natural disasters and climate change — it is also exacerbated by conflict and terrorism. In regions affected by conflict, armed groups leverage food insecurity to further their destructive agendas, using it as both a recruitment tool and a weapon to sow discord. In May, we witnessed a clear example of that, when the Palestinian Islamic Jihad fired mortars at the Erez and Kerem Shalom border crossings between Israel and the Gaza Strip. The deliberate targeting of humanitarian corridors put the transport of people and crucial supplies in immediate danger. Nevertheless, even in those cases, Israel worked to have the crossings open again within hours.

Recent global challenges and geopolitical tensions remind us that such far-reaching threats have global repercussions, affecting food supply chains and prices, especially among vulnerable communities. Ultimately, the ripple effects of pandemics, terrorism and global

conflict have created a devastating cycle of scarcity, hunger and vulnerability. We must remain vigilant to the broader implications of food insecurity and work collectively to ensure that food remains a source of sustenance, not a tool of manipulation. In that regard, Israel is concerned by the potential implications on food security and global food prices if the Black Sea Grain Initiative is not extended and encourages Russia to agree to its renewal for the benefit of the peoples in the Middle East, Africa and beyond. Israel remains committed to sharing its experience, collaborating and building capacity globally.

We align ourselves with your vision and decision, Mr. President, to put this urgent issue high on our global agenda.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Belarus.

Mr. Rybakov (Belarus) (*spoke in Russian*): Belarus aligns itself with the statement made by the representative of Venezuela on behalf of the Group of Friends in Defence of the Charter of the United Nations.

We thank the delegation of the United States of America for the opportunity to discuss global food security. Belarus cannot support the joint communiqué. The text of the document was not submitted for our consideration in keeping with best democratic practices, nor were there any consultations or opportunities provided to propose changes or amendments. The document does not say a word about one of the main threats to food security, namely, illegal unilateral sanctions. At various levels and in different forums, we have repeatedly drawn the international community's attention to the fact that the sanctions illegally imposed on Belarus by Western countries, including against its potash fertilizer sector, have had extremely negative consequences for global food security.

At the same time, we can say with conviction that the infamous exemptions from such sanctions, which are often publicly announced, including today in this Chamber, are divorced from reality and do not work. Sanctions are fully blocking the export of fertilizers and foodstuff from Belarus. Potassium is crucial to maximizing crop yields. Fertilizer determines future harvests. Half of the food consumed by the world's population is produced owing to fertilizer. Removing fertilizer from fields means a drop in crop yields of at least 50 per cent. One out of two people in the world depends on agricultural products that have been grown

with fertilizers. Belarus is one of the largest producers of potash fertilizers in the world. Before the illegal termination of the transport of Belarusian potassium through Baltic Sea ports, which, incidentally, constitutes a direct violation of the rights of a landlocked country, Belarus' share in the world potash fertilizer market was approximately 20 per cent. Just think about it: one out every five tons of potash fertilizer in the world had come from Belarus.

The illegal unilateral actions of Lithuania and other Western countries to block supplies of Belarusian fertilizer have already jeopardized the food security of not only individual countries, but entire regions and continents. Our country's market share of potash fertilizer in Africa fell from 42 per cent to 3 per cent in 2022. According to our estimates, based on data from the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations, the virtual disappearance of Belarus from the list of potash suppliers last year led to a 16 per cent drop in Africa's grain harvest. In 2023, Belarusian potash supplies to Africa are completely paralysed, owing to Lithuania's actions. We should also keep in mind that many countries on the continent had received all their entire supply of fertilizer from Belarus, while a number of other countries had met 50 per cent of their fertilizer needs with potash from Belarus.

The effects of the fertilizer shortage throughout the world have already spilled over from corn and wheat to all major staple crops, including rice, which in the near future will inevitably have a devastating impact on the lives of billions of people in Asia and South America. At future meetings, rather than the lack of access to fertilizer, we will be forced to discuss horrifying statistics concerning the victims of starvation, owing to the lack of food. Reports and studies by authoritative international organizations and agencies, such as the United Nations, the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the World Bank and the International Fertilizer Association corroborate Belarus' own assessments that the current shortage of potash fertilizer on world markets will significantly reduce crop yields and will inevitably cause a sharp rise in food prices.

Many farmers have already been forced to cut back on production, as the fertilizers that they require have become more expensive than the grain that they grow and sell. Illegal sanctions are a weapon of war. They have been unilaterally imposed against the Republic of Belarus in violation of all norms of international

law without the approval of the Security Council under spurious pretexts. Those who have devised and implemented the sanctions are violating the most basic human right — the right to life — condemning millions of people to starvation and death. Western States must stop using illegal unilateral sanctions as their preferred instrument of war. That would be their true contribution to ensuring global food security.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Saudi Arabia.

Mr. Alwasil (Saudi Arabia) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, my country aligns itself with the statement made by the representative of Oman on behalf of the States members of the Gulf Cooperation Council.

I would like to congratulate you, Mr. President, and the United States of America, on assuming the presidency of the Security Council for this month. We would like to thank the United States for convening this timely debate on famine and conflict-induced global food insecurity, as the entire international community is facing increasing challenges. We, the members of this Organization, must spare no effort to find practical solutions to address the crisis of famine everywhere and prevent its severe ramifications for States and communities due to conflict-induced food insecurity.

My country, the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, is following with great interest developments at the regional and international arenas concerning the many crises and conflicts that have regrettably undermined the international community's ability to address their impacts on food security and States' stability, let alone the humanitarian consequences on peoples. The Council is well aware of my country's efforts related to the provision of humanitarian aid in response to urgent and non-urgent humanitarian appeals. Those efforts include ensuring food security in various conflict areas throughout the world, beginning with our brotherly and neighbouring countries in the region, such as Yemen, Palestine, Syria, the Sudan, Lebanon, Somalia and other friendly countries and peoples, such as Pakistan, Ukraine, the Rohingya refugees and those in need in many other countries. That is in addition to the aid that we provide to many humanitarian non-governmental organizations and United Nations relief and humanitarian bodies and agencies worldwide. The aid provided by the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia has surpassed \$87.13 billion, making it the largest donor of humanitarian and development aid at the Arab and Islamic levels and one of the three major donors at

the international level. The Kingdom will continue its humanitarian efforts to respond to the call for relief throughout the world.

Addressing the drivers and root causes of conflict has become urgent and imperative. If we fail to do so, we will be unable to ensure food security around the world, particularly as the nature of conflicts has changed and become unpredictable in terms of the forms they may take. That has been concurrent with increased levels of famine and food insecurity in many regions. The international community should therefore make concerted efforts not only to provide relief to people in need, but also to find political, economic and development solutions that will contribute to ending ongoing conflicts and reducing the likelihood of their emergence in other regions. Undoubtedly, challenges related to security and armed conflicts pose the greatest challenges and threat to global food security and development. The situation becomes even worse when conflicts and wars intensify and spread, as development and food security can never be achieved without peace.

We also recall that, in addition to conflicts and wars, climate change exacerbates the food security crisis. Therefore, the Kingdom stresses the importance of international efforts to strengthen climate action and the resilience of Member States, in particular developing countries. The Kingdom of Saudi Arabia has taken important steps to enhance food security. We have developed strategies aimed at promoting food growth and addressing the challenges of climate change and the scarcity of water resources. Such efforts have contributed to improving food security indicators in the Kingdom.

In conclusion, my country attaches great importance to development issues and humanitarian efforts that help to support the countries most in need, promote their sustainability, support them in addressing common challenges and risks, improve food security and eliminate hunger and poverty, in implementation of Sustainable Development Goal 2. The Kingdom's foreign policy attaches the utmost importance to consolidating security and stability, supporting dialogue and political and peaceful solutions, and providing conditions that support development and fulfil the aspirations of peoples for a better tomorrow, whether in the Middle East or in the entire world. Our peace efforts testify to that goal. We always emphasize the importance of promoting the values of pluralism and international

cooperation, as stipulated in the Charter of the United Nations, in order to overcome growing international challenges, bring about a more inclusive and just world, and promote prosperity and well-being for all peoples.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Azerbaijan.

Mr. Aliyev (Azerbaijan): I would like to start by thanking the United States presidency for convening today's important meeting on a topic to which my country attaches particular importance.

Back in 2021, Azerbaijan contributed to the Council's open debate on conflict and hunger (see S/2021/250) by submitting a written statement by the Minister for Foreign Affairs.

The Security Council's relevant resolution, resolution 2417 (2018), recognized that conflict can affect food security, both directly and indirectly, among other things by displacing people from land, livestock grazing areas and fishing grounds or by the destruction of agricultural assets and disruption to food systems.

Azerbaijan experienced first-hand conflict-driven threats to its food security during nearly 30 years of occupation of some 20 per cent of its territory by Armenia. The aggression caused long-term and severe damage to food production capacity, with widespread land degradation, pillaged and destroyed water infrastructure and polluted water resources. In particular, the mismanagement by Armenia of the Sarsang water reservoir, the centrepiece of the water supply network in the Karabakh region of Azerbaijan, provoked a humanitarian crisis, as 400,000 Azerbaijanis living in the downstream regions were deprived of water for both domestic and agricultural purposes. It also caused severe environmental impacts, such as soil erosion, dehydration and desertification. Those negative impacts remain ongoing to date, along with the continued severe pollution of transboundary rivers, in particular the Okchuchay and Aras, flowing from Armenia into Azerbaijan.

Substantial areas of Azerbaijan's farmland were spoiled and fragmented by the construction of trenches, tunnels and other defensive fortifications by Armenia. The decades-long military engineering activities of Armenia have caused significant land disturbance, affecting vegetation cover, water infiltration and surface water flows. Most disturbingly, Armenia planted more than 1.5 million landmines on our territory, contaminating more than 3,000 square miles

of Azerbaijan's land, half of which was previously arable territory.

The refusal by Armenia to disclose the exact location of landmines has already claimed 57 innocent lives and severely injured 247 persons. In addition, it obstructs the reconstruction, reintegration and rehabilitation of those areas, delaying the safe reclamation of the highly fertile agricultural lands that are vital for food security.

In her message to the second International Conference on Mine Action, held this year in Azerbaijan, the United Nations Mine Action Service Director qualified Azerbaijan "as one of the countries most densely contaminated by landmines and explosive remnants of war". As in its resolution 2417 (2018), today's presidential statement (S/PRST/2023/4) particularly expressed

"its deep concern over the serious humanitarian threat posed to civilians by landmines, explosive remnants of war and improvised explosive devices in affected countries, which has serious and lasting social and economic consequences, including regarding food security, for the populations of such countries".

Therefore, Armenia must provide, without any delay, precise and complete information on the minefields.

With regard to the allegations made by the representative of Armenia earlier today, Azerbaijan condemns Armenia's consistent efforts to abuse the issue of humanitarian assistance for its malign purposes. The establishment of the Lachin border checkpoint is an undeniable sovereign right of Azerbaijan — the same as the right of any other State to secure and protect its borders and guarantee the security of persons, vehicles and cargo movement along the road. In fact, on 6 July, the International Court of Justice unanimously rejected Armenia's request for provisional measures with respect to the checkpoint, essentially ruling that Armenia's claims are groundless.

Since the checkpoint began operations, civilian traffic between the Karabakh region of Azerbaijan and Armenia, in both directions, increased significantly. Armenia consistently resorted to provocations to disrupt the functioning of the road and, on 15 June, opened sniper fire, as a result of which an Azerbaijani border officer was wounded.

Moreover, Armenia has recklessly exploited vehicles hired by the International Committee of the

Red Cross (ICRC) for the smuggling of goods, such as electronic devices, microchips and other dual-use technologies, to supply its illegally deployed armed forces in the sovereign territory of Azerbaijan. That is a blatant violation of international humanitarian law and a serious blow to the humanitarian mandate and reputation of the International Committee of the Red Cross.

Azerbaijan's consistent calls on Armenia for cooperation through border and customs entities to ensure the smooth functioning of the road for the movement of persons, cargo and services have remained unanswered. Azerbaijan has also proposed that the ICRC use the Aghdam-Khankendi route for its humanitarian activities. That proposal was reiterated by Azerbaijan at the recent meeting between the leaders of Azerbaijan and Armenia in Brussels, organized by the President of the European Council, who, in his public remarks, encouraged the use of the Aghdam-Khankendi route as an important part of ensuring that the needs of the Karabakh residents are met. The issue was also discussed between the foreign ministers of Azerbaijan and Armenia in Moscow at the end of July.

However, the road is currently closed, with concrete blocks by the Armenian side not allowing cargo and vehicles, including those belonging to the ICRC, to pass. Such an arbitrary denial of humanitarian assistance reveals Armenia's sinister intention to create a false narrative of a so-called "humanitarian crisis" in the region.

Instead, Armenia has to abide by its international obligations, completely withdraw its armed forces from the territory of Azerbaijan, cease and desist from territorial claims, illegal activities and disinformation, put an end to mine terrorism, shed light on the fate of some 4,000 Azerbaijanis who went missing during the conflict, redress the harm caused to Azerbaijan, including to its food security systems, and engage faithfully in negotiations on a peace treaty and the delimitation of borders between the two States.

Azerbaijan is firm in its determination to protect its people, sovereignty and territorial integrity, and is fully committed to the objectives of a peaceful, secure, stable and prosperous region.

Mr. Ferreira Silva Aranda (Portugal): We would like to congratulate the United States for assuming the presidency of the Security Council for the month

of August and to commend you, Mr. President, for convening this timely debate.

Today's discussion is a welcome follow-up to the meeting on conflict-driven food insecurity held in March 2021 (see S/2021/250) and to the ministerial-level meeting on food security that took place in May last year (see S/PV.9036).

Portugal aligns itself with the statement delivered on behalf of the European Union. Allow me now to add the following remarks in our national capacity.

The relation between conflicts and food insecurity is unmistakable and reciprocal, as unanimously recognized by the Security Council five years ago, in resolution 2417 (2018). Conflicts impair food security, and food insecurity leads to conflicts.

One of the most recent and clear examples of the first phenomenon is the impact that Russia's aggression against Ukraine is having on global food security. The Black Sea Grain Initiative was of paramount importance to mitigate disruptions in the global trade of grains. It is crucial to resume the Initiative as a matter of urgency, and we join others in condemning attacks on civilian infrastructure. In order to ensure the availability and accessibility of food, fertilizers and energy, which are essential for the realization of individuals' right to food, it is necessary that we all redouble efforts to achieve a fair and lasting peace worldwide.

A new approach to peace and security, one more focused on conflict prevention and fully embedded in respect for human rights and international humanitarian law, would contribute to accelerated progress towards zero hunger by precluding the effects conflicts have on food security. In that context, we encourage the United Nations to embrace the recommendations put forward by the Secretary-General in *Our Common Agenda* (A/75/982) and, more recently, in the New Agenda for Peace policy brief.

We also need to do more to scale up the emergency response and, simultaneously, to improve the resilience of countries' food systems, in particular those of developing countries, which face several challenges, such as climate change. Steps such as the supply of affordable agricultural inputs and products, investments in small-scale infrastructure, short-term credit and better access to markets and commercial information may play an important role in that regard.

In conclusion, let me reiterate that hunger can never be used as a weapon or a tactic in a conflict. Nor can humanitarian access be instrumentalized or attacks against humanitarian workers tolerated. The weaponization of food security targets, first and foremost, the most vulnerable populations — precisely those whom we should try the hardest to protect.

Ms. Mrad (Lebanon) (*spoke in Arabic*): We congratulate the delegation of the United States of America on the assumption of the presidency of the Security Council for this month and express our appreciation for convening this open debate on the use of food security as a weapon of war in armed conflict.

At a time of intertwined multifaceted crises with overlapping objectives, the world hardly closed one chapter to be confronted by other chapters of affliction, some as a result of the wrath of Mother Nature and others caused by humans. In both cases, human beings and unarmed civilians are the ones who pay the heaviest price — reduced security in all its aspects, including food security.

Until recently, the scarcity of natural resources, water and land unsuitable for agriculture and production, in addition to global warming, which are all interlinked, have been the main causes of food insecurity, especially in the countries of the South, despite their wealth in natural resources. Today, there are many imminent threats to global food security owing to the absence of rules in war. Wars also have rules and ethics, notably to spare unarmed civilians and to not use them as human shields. Therefore, cutting off food — whether by obstructing supply and export channels or by a system of sanctions that undermines humanitarian assistance during conflicts — is tantamount to using citizens as human shields.

Lebanon, with worsening food difficulties, has become one of 20 countries subject to hunger, following a severe economic crisis that has been going on for three years. We reiterate our position on the issue of food security by supporting resolution 2417 (2018), adopted by consensus, which stressed the link between armed conflict, violence and the risk of famine in a step that transcends politicization of the dossier, whose main and ultimate focus is the human being, nature, the future of people and their sustainability.

Any measure taken in this regard must inevitably find a means to address the food security agenda and secure the financial aid allocated to it. It must also be

detached from political considerations. We must not take sides or maintain strenuous international policies against small countries, like Lebanon, which has been torn apart by many economic crises.

The starting point for concerted international efforts, regardless of political differences, is the commitment to the United Nations conventions on ensuring food security at the global level and the need to resume and extend the Black Sea Grain Initiative, in its entirety, under the umbrella of the United Nations, thus contributing to the arrival of food products to the most vulnerable countries and the peoples in need of those vital resources.

In conclusion, the world today needs an integrated strategy to address the worsening situation with regard to food insecurity and food in general with a view to achieving Sustainable Development Goal 2, namely, ending hunger and achieving food security. We must adopt a memorandum of understanding or an international protocol to be added to the rules of wars, conflicts and sanctions, whether imposed unilaterally or by the United Nations, that prohibits the use of food security as a means of war or applying pressure because ultimately the people are the only ones affected by that.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of the Philippines.

Mr. Lagdameo (Philippines): I would like to thank you, Mr. President, and the United States for convening today's open debate on famine and conflict-induced global food insecurity.

Recent indicators show that our goal of ending hunger, food insecurity and malnutrition in all its forms by 2030 remains out of reach. The 2023 report *The State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World* reveals that global hunger remained relatively unchanged from 2021 to 2022 and is still far above pre-coronavirus disease pandemic levels. It also reflects that hunger is still on the rise throughout Africa, Western Asia and the Caribbean, and that the modest progress in general has been undermined by rising food and energy prices magnified by the war in Ukraine.

Furthermore, according to this year's annual report of the Secretary-General on the protection of civilians (S/2023/345), more than a quarter of a billion people faced acute hunger in 58 countries and territories in 2022. Conflict and violence were the most significant drivers of high levels of acute food insecurity for approximately 117 million people in 19 countries

and territories. The causes of conflict-induced food insecurity in those and other conflict situations included direct harm to food and water sources and impediments to food and water production, delivery and access.

As pronounced by Philippine President Ferdinand Marcos Jr. during the seventy-seventh session of the General Assembly last year:

“Food is not just a trade commodity or a livelihood, it is an existential imperative as well as a moral one. It is the very basis of human security.”
(A/77/PV.5, p. 5)

The Philippines has faced head-on the two-pronged problem of the food crisis: that which hits us in the short term and that which hits us in the long term. The agricultural sector is one of the main drivers of our push for growth. The Philippine Development Plan, the blueprint for its development transformation, puts in place coherent strategic measures to hasten economic and social recovery towards inclusive and resilient development. It puts together measures to address the current energy and food crises in the context of a new system for energy, climate and nature.

On that point, I wish to highlight the following.

First, under the framework of the peacebuilding efforts in Mindanao, the Enhanced Comprehensive Local Integration Program reintegrates former rebels by giving them training, education, housing and livelihood. Since 2016, a total of 36,808 former rebels and 3,033 violent extremists have been reintegrated. That is complemented by initiatives from other Government agencies such as the Department of Agriculture and the Department of Social Welfare and Development.

Secondly, the Barangay Development Program, another Government initiative within the smallest administrative divisions or barangays in the country, continues to bring development to former conflict-ridden communities. It is directed towards the sustainable rehabilitation of 822 barangays.

Thirdly, there is a need to align anticipatory initiatives by all stakeholders to prevent acute famine caused by conflict and climate change. That can be through enhanced information-sharing and coordination to identify early warning signs of famine and food security; increased funding support for humanitarian and development programmes in vulnerable regions; and global solidarity and the mobilization of international support.

Fourthly, there is a need to enhance collaboration and accountability to increase access to civilians in need of life-saving assistance during conflict, with a focus on children, women and girls. The Philippines is the first country in the region to launch a national action plan on women and peace and security. The plan integrates the women and peace and security pillars of prevention, participation and protection with elements such as addressing the proliferation of small arms.

Fifthly, there is a need for a whole-of-Government approach engaging various stakeholders; long-term investments focusing on sustainable solutions such as agricultural development and economic empowerment; and leveraging data and technology.

Finally, United Nations agencies and international organizations should work together and with Governments towards addressing the issue of food insecurity — from raising awareness, generating political will and building resilience to promoting conflict resolution. The role of the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations, the World Food Programme (WFP) and other United Nations agencies and funds can augment the efforts of States in that regard. In the Philippines, for instance, WFP has helped the Government's efforts in rebuilding lives and responding to climate, conflict and disaster.

An impactful and transformative international collaboration to address global food insecurity, including in places where it is exacerbated owing to conflicts, is needed more than ever.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of the Plurinational State of Bolivia.

Mr. Pary Rodríguez (Plurinational State of Bolivia) (*spoke in Spanish*): Bolivia thanks the presidency of the Security Council for convening this debate. My delegation associates itself with the statement made by Venezuela on behalf of the Group of Friends in Defence of the Charter of the United Nations.

Global food insecurity is definitely the result of conflicts, but it is not responsible to attribute that problem to current geopolitical frictions alone. In this frank discussion, we must not ignore the nefarious processes of colonization in Africa, Asia and the Americas and their legacy, which were the product of old rivalries among Powers. Based on that, we can see that the main cause of peoples' vulnerability to hunger is poverty, and the main factor that explains their poverty is the history of colonial exploitation. Therefore, the

international community must prioritize investments in equitable, sustainable and resilient agrifood systems to end poverty and hunger, based on the recognition of those historical responsibilities.

The current systemic crisis is an opportunity to re-evaluate our priorities, since there can be no sustainable development without peace and security, and there can be no peace and security without sustainable development.

According to estimates by specialized institutions, we saw in 2021 a record in global military spending, exceeding \$2 trillion annually for the first time in history. It also has been estimated that, in order to be able to end to hunger in the next 10 years, it would require \$330 billion dollars. In other words, if only 2 per cent of what is spent annually on war were invested in food security with sovereignty, debates such as this one would not be necessary and, in just 10 years, would never be convened again.

The Security Council could contribute much more to building a renewed multilateralism by working to expand the regions that have been declared zones of peace and abandoning short-sighted geopolitical ambitions. Only by doing that will we be able to contribute to a multipolar world that faithfully reflects the principles of the Charter and in which there is no threat to the right to food for society's most vulnerable segments.

Finally, the Plurinational State of Bolivia believes that in order to eradicate world food insecurity, we must transform investments in death into investments for life. It is urgent that we comply with our historical commitments and establish new ones providing financing for development and climate action, without forgetting that our collective action should be commensurate with the historical debts among peoples and to Mother Earth.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Tunisia.

Mr. Ladeb (Tunisia) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, I congratulate the United States of America on assuming the presidency of the Security Council for this month and commend its initiative in convening this important debate. Tunisia aligns itself with the presidential statement (S/PRST/2023/4) issued on the topic of today's meeting. I would also like to thank the briefers for their valuable insights.

The choice of today's topic, famine and conflict-induced global food insecurity, stresses the issue's importance and our growing collective awareness of its gravity, as well as the need for the international community to join forces in order to find good solutions that can mitigate its consequences and contain its ramifications, especially for developing and least developed countries, which continue to witness increasing rates of poverty and starvation. In that context, it is important to focus on the factors that are directly or indirectly affecting food security around the world. In addition to climate change and the economic and energy crises, armed conflicts are one of the main causes of starvation, exposing millions of people around the world to the dangers of famine and its effects on global food security, and to disruptions of production chains, distribution routes and price stability.

Recent wars and armed conflicts have revealed the interconnected nature of global food systems, the extent of their fragility and their grave implications for global food security. The effects of conflicts are not limited to the regions where they take place, especially given the links between the trading system and the reliance of many countries, particularly developing countries, on food imports that are vulnerable to global price increases. In that context, it is more than ever the duty of the international community to address the root causes of crises and take proactive measures to reduce famine worldwide and contain the consequences of conflicts. The maintenance of global food security is a pillar of international peace and security and a benchmark for a more balanced, united and equitable world. In that regard, we reiterate the proposal made by President Kaïs Saïed of Tunisia at the Food Systems Summit held by the United Nations in Rome on 24 July, in which he called for creating a strategic grain stock that could be used in times of need in order to prevent food from being turned into a weapon, especially against developing countries.

We call for addressing food-related issues according to a new vision based on genuine human solidarity and effective synergies, and for refraining from exploiting this vital good in any way to achieve political and economic ends. There is also a need to address all the factors that fuel and prolong conflicts, especially considering that the consequences of such crises have no borders and that no one in today's world is immune to them.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Cambodia.

Mrs. Eat (Cambodia): To begin with, Sir, I would like to congratulate the United States on its assumption of the presidency of the Security Council, and to thank your delegation for convening today's debate on famine and conflict-induced global food insecurity. I also thank the briefers and the speakers before me for their insights on this topic. Allow me to share the following thoughts.

First, my delegation deeply appreciates the prevailing recognition that peace and security are closely linked to food security, as reflected in the Council's unanimous adoption of its resolution 2417 (2018) and the views expressed today. With its own first-hand experience of conflict-induced famine and food insecurity, Cambodia would like to re-emphasize the importance of prioritizing peacebuilding and conflict prevention, particularly in the light of current worrisome trends. We support the suggestion that the Peacebuilding Commission should play a bigger advisory role on appropriate actions in conflict areas.

Secondly, we support the calls for parties to armed conflicts to respect international humanitarian law. Weaponizing food supplies and depriving people of access to food by any means is a violation of human rights.

Thirdly, while many efforts have been made to confront famine and acute malnutrition, the *Global Report on Food Crises 2023* still shows a bleak picture. My delegation wholeheartedly supports the call for enhanced public-private partnerships. We commend the strategic and macro-level efforts, but perhaps more can be done at the micro level to mobilize support from the private sector and private individuals through more campaigns at the grass-roots level and by creating a simple system for allocating contributions, even very small ones, that go to helping people in need of food in specific parts of the world. The United Nations, national Governments, the private sector and civil society could work in partnership to that end.

Fourthly, to strengthen the resilience of food systems in the face of climate change, we should make coordinated efforts to mobilize more funding for adaptation. We strongly welcome the commitment to increasing investment for adaptation and support calls for innovative approaches. We suggest that concerted efforts should be made to match partners in carbon trading as a way to generate funds for adaptation

activities such as the expansion of best practices on climate-resilient food crop cultivation, the application of modern technology and — because people need more land to cultivate — investment in studies on whether certain food crops or plantations can serve as carbon sinks, as natural forests do.

Finally, Cambodia hopes that by redoubling their efforts, Member States will be able to achieve Sustainable Development Goal 2 by 2030, as we aspire to.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Myanmar.

Mr. Tun (Myanmar): First of all, Myanmar thanks the presidency of the United States for organizing today's high-level open debate. I would also like to express our appreciation to the briefers for their insightful presentations.

We all have a global target for ending hunger and achieving food security by 2030, yet we are clearly off track. The consequences of the coronavirus disease pandemic, conflicts and climate change are making the situation worse. According to United Nations projections, 8 per cent of the world's population, nearly 670 million people, will still be facing hunger by 2030. That will constitute a failure of the global efforts to achieve Sustainable Development Goal 2.

Along with other factors, conflicts remain a key driver of food insecurity. The focus of today's debate could not be more timely, with a major war raging in Europe and instability and conflicts emerging in many parts of the world following unconstitutional changes in Government. The international community must therefore find ways to minimize the impact of armed conflicts on the food security of millions of people, particularly those living in conflict-affected areas. As a diplomat from a country affected by conflict, I have to emphasize that the reality of people suffering various kinds of ills, including food insecurity, is indeed a complete misery.

In Myanmar, a decade of democratic reforms and hard-won momentum aimed at reducing poverty have been eliminated by the illegitimate military junta following the illegal coup of February 2021. The military junta's systematic destruction of the rule of law, and its atrocities against the people of Myanmar, have created a multifaceted crisis with regional implications. Approximately 15.2 million people are food-insecure. There are nearly 1.9 million internally

displaced people in Myanmar. Malnutrition is hitting children in Myanmar particularly hard. According to the World Food Programme, nearly 1 in 3 children in Myanmar under the age of 5 suffer from stunting and 7 percent of all children nationally suffer from wasting.

While the rising poverty in Myanmar is pushing more and more people into hunger, the deteriorating food security is largely the result of the junta's inhumane "four cuts" military campaign. Since the illegal coup, the junta forces have displaced 1.6 million people by committing atrocities against the civilian population and deploying indiscriminate artillery shelling and air strikes on residential towns and villages. Moreover, a key tactic that the military junta uses consistently is the systematic and widespread burning of civilian homes. So far they have burned down more than 70,000 civilian properties. The junta forces subsequently destroy their livelihoods by preventing them from farming or harvesting their crops. The junta's targeted destruction of homes and livelihoods has significantly disrupted food production in many parts of the country.

Another serious issue is the military junta's weaponization of humanitarian access. It is essential that aid workers be able to deliver life-saving humanitarian assistance to those in greatest need, based on the fundamental humanitarian principles of humanity, neutrality, impartiality and independence. However, the denial or restriction of access by the junta has been a constant challenge for humanitarian actors, including the United Nations agencies in Myanmar. Such denials and undue restrictions are violations of international humanitarian law.

In conclusion, the Security Council can do more to minimize the effects of conflict-induced food insecurity in many situations. In the case of Myanmar, the Council has made repeated calls and demands, including through its resolution 2669 (2022), for an immediate end to all forms of violence and for full, safe and unhindered humanitarian access in Myanmar. However, the Council has yet to hold the military junta accountable for the war crimes it is repeatedly committing against the civilian population, as well as for its consistent international crimes and violations of international humanitarian law, including the denial of humanitarian access.

Decisive action on the part of the Security Council will help the people of Myanmar in their steadfast efforts to restore democracy, peace and stability in their country. The vast majority of them are united in

opposition to the military dictatorship. The junta is not capable of winning its war against them, governing the country, managing the economy or delivering durable peace and stability. Only an inclusive, federal, democratic civilian Government in Myanmar can deliver those goals — and that is exactly what the democratic forces in the country are committed to establishing. I therefore urge the Security Council to follow up with action enforcing its repeated demands for an end to violence and the granting of unhindered humanitarian access in Myanmar. It is high time that the members of the Security Council started a negotiation process to adopt a timely and enforceable resolution on Myanmar.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Pakistan.

Mr. Mohammad Aamir Khan (Pakistan): Pakistan expresses its gratitude to the United States for convening today's high-level open debate on famine and conflict-induced global food insecurity. We also thank the briefers who spoke earlier today for their valuable insights and enriching perspectives.

It is tragic that last year there were approximately 258 million food-insecure people living in 58 mostly developing countries. The primary drivers of food insecurity are underdevelopment, such recent economic shocks as the impacts of the coronavirus disease and climate change, and conflicts old and new. Notably, 117 million of the 258 million people who are food-insecure live in 19 war and conflict zones. Pakistan is concerned about the fact that according to the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations and the World Food Programme, 15.3 million Afghans are projected to face a high level of food insecurity, and we will continue to provide support to the 29 million Afghans in need of humanitarian assistance and to help revive Afghanistan's economy.

While food insecurity accompanies most conflict situations, it becomes particularly acute and endemic in situations of prolonged foreign occupation. Attention in this debate has been devoted to some of those situations but not others. I would like to draw special attention to the situation of the peoples of occupied Palestine and Jammu and Kashmir. Both of those peoples have suffered under foreign occupation for seven decades. They have been subjected to blockades, lockdowns and collective punishments, including deliberate economic and food deprivation, and so far have been virtually abandoned by an indifferent international community.

The best solution to food insecurity in conflict zones is to end the use of force and violence as quickly as possible and to arrive at durable and just settlements of those conflicts. In the case of Jammu and Kashmir, the Security Council must ensure the implementation of its resolutions calling for a United Nations-supervised plebiscite to enable the people of Jammu and Kashmir to exercise their inalienable right to self-determination. Meanwhile, the world community must ensure that economic deprivation and food insecurity are not exploited by the Indian occupation in order to crush the Kashmiri people's legitimate struggle for freedom.

We support ending the war in Ukraine without delay, in accordance with the principles of the Charter of the United Nations and international agreements. Pakistan has commended the Secretary-General's Black Sea Grain Initiative, which aimed to ease the impact of the Ukraine war and its attendant detriment to food security. We hope the Initiative will be revived as soon as possible with the concurrence of the parties and implemented effectively and comprehensively.

We believe that food insecurity in conflict zones should be addressed comprehensively. That entails ensuring the universal and consistent application of the principles of the Charter of the United Nations, the relevant Security Council resolutions and international law in all conflict situations and in the settlement of disputes. It is double standards and the selective application of international norms that make their violation possible, especially by powerful States.

In conclusion, the food insecurity afflicting so many requires immediate solidarity and structural solutions. In the immediate context, we must mobilize supplies to those facing famine and food insecurity due to any cause. We must expand food production and moderate food prices. We must not cut off supplies through food export bans in manifestations of selfish nationalism. We must expand food production, especially in developing countries facing shortages. We must mitigate the impact of climate change on the most vulnerable countries. We must reform unequal agricultural trade. In order to help the millions of people in need and save thousands of lives, we must act with urgency and solidarity.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Nigeria.

Ms. Dakwak (Nigeria): I thank the United States presidency of the Security Council for the month of August for organizing this very important debate on a

subject that affects all of us globally. I thank the United Nations Famine Prevention and Response Coordinator and our other briefers for their insightful briefings.

Today the world is going through a food crisis that is having a particular impact on the world's most vulnerable countries and economies. The disruptive effects of climate change on livelihoods around the world, as well as those of terrorism, violence and conflict and the multifaceted impacts of the coronavirus disease (COVID-19) pandemic, have been the main contributors to the sustained and deepening food insecurity situation in many parts of the world.

Food insecurity has also been a source of many recent conflicts and a major factor in outbreaks of unrest. The destruction of rural and structural infrastructure, the loss of livestock, deforestation, drought and conflict all have long-term impacts on the food security of societies. The Ukraine war has adversely affected the food supply chain generally, further exacerbating pre-existing food insecurities, while the sudden disruption of national and international food supply chains has created additional food shortages, particularly in countries in greater need. My delegation notes with concern the reports of the World Food Programme (WFP) and the Food and Agricultural Organization of the United Nations (FAO) that point out that 70 per cent of the populations experiencing acute hunger in the world are in conflict-affected areas. Clearly, the production of food is hampered during violent conflicts, and when they last longer than one farming season, people are forced to migrate elsewhere for sustenance.

My delegation has noted the report on the *Hunger Hotspots: FAO-WFP early warnings on acute food insecurity* outlook from June to November 2023, which identifies Nigeria as one of the countries potentially facing starvation and death. We want to inform the Council that while north-eastern Nigeria, which has been under attack by terrorists, has been facing shortages and uncertainties regarding food for more than a decade, death and starvation are not a true depiction of the situation. The displacement of farmers by the insurgencies in our north-east and the challenges posed by climate change in the Lake Chad basin and by banditry in the north-west have led to people's displacement and considerable food shortages. However, both have subsided in the past three years.

The reduction or even stoppage of agricultural activities due to insecurity and displacement has social consequences in some communities, including

increased joblessness. We need to work harder to stop violent conflicts — not least because their harmful impact on the vulnerable is even more dire. As the briefers indicated, women and children are the worst affected. While we are deliberating on agriculture and food security, it is equally important to address cross-cutting issues, including the role of science, technology and innovation, gaps in infrastructure and energy and the importance of building human resource and institutional capacities that can support productivity and inclusion. Insufficient investment in agriculture and social protection continues to be a bottleneck in our efforts to increase food availability. We therefore need to increase investment in agriculture by mobilizing both public and private resources and to attract socially responsible and environmentally sustainable foreign investment in the field of agriculture that also benefits local smallholders.

As we prepare for the Sustainable Development Goals Summit in September and the Summit of the Future next year, it is important that the international community demonstrate greater commitment to the repatriation of illicit financial flows and assets, debt relief for developing countries and assistance in modernizing agriculture in many distressed regions.

For its part, Nigeria has rolled out many initiatives aimed at addressing food-related issues, including in the areas of agricultural education, research and innovation, quality control and access to improved seedlings, as well as in standardizing agricultural practices around the country. Much of that work has been done through partnerships. The current Administration, which has been in office only four months, has declared a state of emergency in food security and put measures in place to remedy the problems, including for the distribution of fertilizers and palliatives for mechanized farming and sustainable food production. The Government is working to enhance the implementation of agricultural policies, including through research applications, reviving extension services, easing input access, strengthening the regulatory framework, facilitating affordable credit, increasing commodity outputs, enhancing processing capacities, broadening access to markets and expanding revenue earnings. The National Food Reserve Agency is also redoubling its efforts to ensure that national food security and incomes are improved through marketing and storage services.

In conclusion, the multifaceted and still-unfolding effects on economies of violent conflicts and wars,

climate change disasters and the COVID-19 pandemic require concrete and robust transformative action if we are to address the food security situation. It will be important to adopt transformative solutions and measures that guarantee the sustainability of our basic natural resources and ecological services, as well as building the resilience of farming communities to boost food production. We urge the United Nations system and development partners to renew their commitment to the full implementation of the Decade of Action on Nutrition 2016–2025 and Decade of Family Farming 2019–2028. Together we can turn the global food crisis into an opportunity by effectively coordinating our policy responses.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Qatar.

Mr. Al-Maawda (Qatar) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, Mr. President, we would like to congratulate your friendly country on assuming the presidency of the Security Council for this month. We welcomed the presence of Secretary of State Antony Blinken at this morning's meeting and thank the briefers for their valuable contributions.

We align ourselves with the statement delivered by the representative of Oman on behalf of the Gulf Cooperation Council.

The interrelated links between armed conflict, violence, famine and food insecurity merit the international community's full attention, as they constitute fundamental humanitarian challenges for many countries and peoples all over the world, particularly in developing and least developed countries. At the same time, various factors in our world today are worsening the threats to food security, particularly the crises on the economic, energy and climate fronts. We must therefore address the deep-rooted causes of famine and food insecurity that pose a threat to the three pillars of the United Nations — international peace and security, development and human rights. We want to stress in that respect the central role of the United Nations and the need to commit to international law with regard to the peaceful settlement of conflicts and respect for the independence and sovereignty of States and non-interference in their domestic affairs, as well as to refraining from the use or threat of force and committing to the principles of providing international humanitarian assistance.

International humanitarian law requires the parties to a conflict to refrain from inflicting harm on civilians and civilian property, particularly infrastructure essential to water supplies and the production and distribution of food. It also prohibits the use of food as a weapon of war leading to starvation, a prohibition that is reaffirmed by resolution 2417 (2018). In that regard, we would like to add that the State of Qatar also endorsed today's joint communiqué.

In fulfilling its humanitarian responsibility to respond to famine and food insecurity, particularly as a result of conflict, Qatar dedicates a significant part of its international assistance to addressing hunger and food shortages. To that end, we earmarked nearly \$43 million this year in response to the Secretary-General's appeal for help for countries facing famine resulting from various causes, including conflicts. We also contributed \$20 million to the Black Sea Grain Initiative to help African countries receive food exports. In addition, my country has contributed \$90 million to the World Food Programme to respond to urgent food needs in Yemen. As is well known, when the need for emergency relief arises the State of Qatar contributes hundreds of tons in assistance through airlifts, including food relief, as we did in the Sudan this year and in Afghanistan prior to that. Qatar is committed to cooperating with the United Nations system in guaranteeing food security and finding relevant sustainable solutions. We launched the Global Dryland Alliance initiative, a mechanism designed to fill gaps in the areas of scientific research, strategies and policy in order to enable dryland countries to achieve food security and prevent food crises.

In conclusion, we reiterate how urgent it is to prioritize efforts to address the humanitarian consequences of crises during conflicts, particularly those that threaten food security, and we emphasize that there can be no alternative to international consensus and cooperation if we are to resolve such humanitarian issues and their root causes.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Haiti.

Mr. Rodrigue (Haiti) (*spoke in French*): Let me first of all welcome the United States presidency of the Security Council for the month of August and wish it every success.

I am also grateful for the convening of this high-level debate on a very topical issue, and I commend the

presidency on the quality of the corresponding concept note (see S/2023/560, annex).

The link between conflicts and food insecurity, including their links to famine, can no longer be questioned, as was well underscored in resolution 2417 (2018). Reports of international agencies are sounding the alarm about the scale of this scourge, which is a threat to international peace and security, although the international community's myriad bold efforts to put an end to the problem have yet to yield results commensurate with what is at stake. The Roadmap for Global Food Security and its call to action of May 2022, and the declaration of the Leaders' Summit on Global Food Security, are commendable initiatives. However, it is clear that they remain insufficient in view of the alarming increase in acute food insecurity worldwide. More than a quarter of a billion people now face acute levels of hunger, and some are on the brink of starvation. As Secretary-General António Guterres writes in his foreword to the *Global Report on Food Crises 2023*, "That's unconscionable."

Today's debate is therefore especially meaningful, and as the concept note so judiciously underscores, can contribute to developing synergies between the main State and non-State players in order to strengthen global food systems and prevent future famines. We will also have to address the issue of reducing the effects of conflicts and even ending them altogether. My country, Haiti, is unfortunately on the list of States that are affected by food insecurity, in our case an acute food insecurity that is affecting almost half the population. The situation is the result of a serious multidimensional crisis, marked by a deteriorating security environment created by the indiscriminate violence of armed gangs operating virtually unchecked in many areas of the country, including the capital city of Port-au-Prince. The latest reports on food insecurity in our country are extremely alarming.

For example, the National Commission for Food Security, the Government body responsible for food security in Haiti, has reported that 4.9 million people in the country are food insecure and require emergency humanitarian aid for the period from March to June 2023. The recent report on food security risks in conflict-affected countries, published by the Secretariat, confirms that almost 5 million people in Haiti are currently facing acute food insecurity, including 1.8 million who are facing emergency conditions. It has been clearly established that food insecurity is linked

to the environment of indiscriminate violence created by the armed gangs. In other words, the violence perpetrated by armed groups is having a devastating impact on our communities, hindering their access to food, basic services and livelihoods.

The Haitian Government fully acknowledges the scale of the food crisis and the seriousness of the situation. In that regard, we are committed to overcoming this major challenge with determination and to implementing concrete measures to alleviate the suffering of our citizens affected by food insecurity. Our efforts to that end include the reinstatement of the canteen programme in public schools and, in cooperation with unions, the implementation of a subsidy programme for workers to help them cope with the high cost of living. There can be no question that the food crisis in Haiti calls for a global response based on solidarity. In order to tackle food insecurity more effectively, we need to address its structural and cyclical causes. We therefore call on international partners to ramp up support for national production by continuing to provide farmers with the aid they need such as agricultural equipment, seeds and fertilizers, and assistance in strengthening agricultural cooperatives. Similarly, the construction of agricultural infrastructure and the restoration of irrigation canals are crucial to boosting agricultural production, which would go a long way to reducing the levels of food insecurity and easing unemployment in rural areas. In that regard, we once again call on the international community to intensify its support for the rapid and effective implementation of ongoing humanitarian programmes.

We are also requesting additional technical and financial assistance to strengthen our institutions and crisis-management capacities and help build a secure and stable environment that will be conducive to economic recovery. Our Government is already working closely with international partners and humanitarian agencies to ensure the rapid and effective implementation of those measures. The Cooperation Framework for Sustainable Development 2023–2027, signed last April between the Haitian Government and the United Nations system, therefore represents both a vision and a joint strategy for achieving sustainable development in Haiti over the next five years and an extremely significant step forward in the collaboration between the United Nations and the Government of Haiti.

Along the same lines, we must also address the issue of gangs within the country. If we are to make progress in the area, the international community must provide us with robust support to bolster the Haitian National Police in its fight against armed groups. In that regard, the Government of Haiti very much welcomes Kenya's offer to lead a multinational force to provide effective support to Haitian law-enforcement personnel in their fight against armed gangs, whose violence has reached unprecedented levels in many parts of the country, hindering the movement of people and goods and access to food and water. The situation has brought many humanitarian activities to a halt as the population's needs have worsened. We remain confident that Council members will be able to quickly authorize the deployment of such a multinational force, which the Haitian Government has been requesting since October 2022, to help re-establish the peace and security that the country needs to ease the serious food crisis in the country.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Liberia.

Mrs. Fyneah (Liberia): At the outset, I would like to convey warm greetings to the Security Council from President George Manneh Weah of Liberia and his best wishes to the United States for its presidency of the Council for the month of August. I also join other delegations in commending you, Mr. President, for facilitating today's high-level debate on famine and conflict-induced global food insecurity.

We welcome today's discussion, as Liberia is deeply concerned about the alarming rise in global food insecurity caused by armed conflict and climate extremes. We note that food insecurity is also a threat to national and international peace and security and therefore hope that today's debate will keep the spotlight on famine and conflict-induced global food insecurity, and especially that it will strengthen radical collaboration to avert a looming humanitarian crisis. In that connection, the Government of Liberia, under the leadership of President Weah, strongly condemns the use of food as a weapon of war and support in its entirety the United States-led joint communiqué condemning such weaponization. Liberia further recognizes the significant role of the Black Sea Grain Initiative in preventing a humanitarian disaster, laments Russia's termination of the agreement and calls on like-minded countries to say no to the use of food as a weapon.

As the United Nations, we must respect, promote and defend the humanitarian principles of humanity, neutrality, impartiality and independence in the provision of humanitarian assistance and adhere to protocols that prohibit the starvation of civilians as a method of warfare or combat. Liberia firmly believes that through innovative partnerships and radical collaboration, we can begin to confront the challenges of famine and conflict-induced global food insecurity. Today's debate is therefore a defining moment for us to take stock of where we are and what needs to be done to have a positive impact on our world.

The President: I now give the floor to the observer of the Observer State of the Holy See.

Archbishop Caccia (Holy See): The delegation of the Holy See thanks the United States of America for convening today's open debate on famine and food insecurity, an issue that has tragically become more prominent since the escalation of the war in Ukraine. At the outset, it is important to recall that every human person has the right to the means necessary for the proper development of life, particularly food. Despite that, more than a quarter of a billion people currently face high levels of acute food insecurity and depend on assistance in nearly a third of States around the world. The current situation necessitates responsible multilateral cooperation resulting in proactive solidarity with our brothers and sisters who face hunger. That demands that all States put efforts to meet basic human needs above partisan interests and refrain from treating foodstuffs as mere commodities to be awarded to the highest bidder. In that regard, my delegation would like to stress three points.

First, the Holy See urges all the parties concerned to return to dialogue regarding the renewal of the Black Sea Grain Initiative in the interests of all who rely on food imports. We also call for an end to attacks on the means of transportation essential to the supply of agricultural products, food and other basic necessities that are crucial to the survival of civilian populations.

Secondly, the Holy See stresses the need to ensure that economic sanctions avoid any potential negative effects on both local and global food security and the distribution of humanitarian aid.

Thirdly, the Holy See calls on all States to protect our common home, created and entrusted to us by God, and to take urgent action to fight climate change, whose ravages, such as extreme weather events, have

an impact on local food systems and can increase the risk of conflicts.

In conclusion, my delegation reiterates the need for all States to adopt an integral approach to security as a means to alleviate global food insecurity, which constitutes a serious affront to human dignity.

The President: The representative of India has asked for the floor to make a further statement. I give them the floor.

Mr. Ravindran (India): My delegation has asked to make a further statement because yet again we have unfortunately seen a delegation misuse this forum to divert the Council's attention from the important topic of food security. That delegation has unfortunately shown a consistent tendency to exploit various United Nations platforms to further its own agenda. In that regard, I would like to emphasize that India's sovereignty and territorial integrity is non-negotiable. That said, we also consider it unnecessary to engage in arguments or debates, particularly with those who resort to terrorism to advance their unlawful goals. In order to make the best use of the Council's time, I suggest that the delegation concerned concentrate on addressing its internal matters and restoring order within its own borders rather than indulging in frivolous allegations about my country.

The President: The representative of Pakistan has asked for the floor to make a further statement. I give them the floor.

Mrs. Ijaz (Pakistan): I am taking the floor to respond to the remarks made by the representative of India.

The biggest falsehood that India keeps on repeating is that Kashmir is a part of India. My delegation would like to remind India that Kashmir is neither a so-called integral part of India nor an internal matter. It is not a territory of India. In all of its resolutions on the subject, the Security Council has decided that the final disposition of Kashmir will be determined by its people through a United Nations-supervised plebiscite. India has accepted that decision and is bound to comply with it, in accordance with Article 25 of the Charter of the United Nations.

The maps of the United Nations all show Kashmir as a disputed territory. If India has nothing to hide, it must accept a United Nations commission of inquiry and agree to implement the Security Council resolutions stipulating a plebiscite to enable the people of Jammu and Kashmir to exercise their right to self-determination. And if India has any respect for international law and moral courage, it should also end its reign of terror, withdraw its troops and let the Kashmiris freely decide their future, in accordance with the Security Council resolutions.

The meeting rose at 7.30 p.m.